The Discoverability Gap:
Access Barriers and Content Effects in Answer Engine Optimization

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November 2026

Abstract

Answer engines such as ChatGPT and Perplexity answer questions by naming a few organisations and citing sources. Answer engine optimisation (AEO) has focused on editing page content; we argue that access comes first, and test both. Study 1 measures access barriers on 569 organisational websites in 22 sectors and 703 randomly sampled popular sites. One organisational site in three (34.6%; 19.0% without refusals at the network edge) has a barrier to answer engines, usually an implicit one such as a wildcard robots.txt rule, and sites refuse AI training crawlers far more often than answer agents. Study 2 is a pre-specified experiment with fictional brands: 14 page treatments in 12 hosted language models, replicated on 10 models behind widely used assistants. With the pages in the model's context, a third party's recommendation raised the chance that a brand was named by 37.4 percentage points, more than any edit to the brand's own page; citations and statistics added 21.1 and 13.7 points and were passed on to readers, repeated keywords also helped, and a hidden instruction worked on most models but not on Anthropic's. When four models had to search a pool of pages themselves, the brand was named in 22% of baseline answers instead of 53%, evidence edits and the hidden instruction lost their effect because the page was seldom opened, and text matching the question made pages far easier to find. In a live audit, ChatGPT's free tier cited no sources. We release the toolkit, benchmark and data.

1 Introduction

Answer engines such as ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini and Perplexity reply to a question with a written answer that names a few organisations and cites a few sources. Users click through less than they do from a list of links: in a 2025 panel study, they clicked a conventional result on 8% of Google visits that showed an AI summary and on 15% of visits that did not [4]. Being named, recommended and cited in the answer has become a goal in its own right, pursued under the names Answer Engine Optimization (AEO) and Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) [1].

Most research on GEO edits a page that is already in the model's context and measures whether the page becomes more visible in the answer. The findings conflict. Aggarwal et al. [1] reported gains of up to 40% from adding statistics, quotations and citations; C-SEO Bench found most such methods ineffective once many documents compete [34]; and controlled studies find that relevance and position dominate while stylistic cues matter little [38, 39]. Two confounds recur. On real pages a treatment cannot be separated from what the model already knows about the brand, and most treatments add text, so a better page and a longer page are not distinguished.

Before any edit can matter, the engine has to fetch and read the page. Operators run separate agents for model training, search indexing and user-requested fetches, each with its own robots.txt

token (Table 1). Content-delivery networks filter automated clients, and the largest has blocked AI crawlers by default for new customers since July 2025 [6]. Most AI crawlers do not execute JavaScript [37]. Measurements of AI-crawler controls have studied consent to training [8, 23, 26]. How often the same mechanisms keep sites out of answers, a discoverability gap that no content edit can close, and how that compares with the effect of editing content, has not been measured.

We study both. Section 3 writes the probability that an engine names an organisation as a product of access, retrieval and selection, so the effect of any content edit is bounded by access. Study 1 (Section 4) measures access barriers for 569 organisational websites in 22 sectors and compares them with 703 randomly sampled popular websites. Study 2 (Section 5) is a pre-specified experiment that places fictional brands in the context of 12 hosted language models from ten developers and applies 14 page treatments, including a length-matched placebo and a hidden instruction to the model; three small local models serve as a comparison. A replication on 10 models behind widely used assistants, further robustness checks, an agentic version in which models search for the pages themselves, and a snapshot audit of Perplexity, Gemini and ChatGPT test how far the results carry. Our main findings:

- **Barriers are common, mostly implicit, and aimed at training.** Of the organisational sites, 34.6% have at least one barrier to AI answer engines (19.0% if refusals at the network edge are excluded), but only 9.3% block an AI search crawler by name; for 25.3% every barrier is implicit (a wildcard rule, an unreachable robots.txt, an edge refusal or JavaScript-only text). Sites block training crawlers far more often than answer agents: 38 block OpenAI's training crawler but not its search crawler, and none the reverse. A random sample of popular sites shows the same asymmetry.
- **Endorsement beats page edits.** With access and retrieval held fixed, a third party's recommendation raised the chance that a brand was named by 37.4 points across 12 hosted models, significantly in every one, and by 29.7 points across 10 further models behind assistants such as ChatGPT, Copilot, Grok and Claude. The best edit to the brand's own page, source citations, added 21.1.
- **Evidence helps and reaches readers, but emphasis helps too.** Citations, statistics and an expert quotation beat both the unedited page and a length-matched placebo, and answers passed the added sources and figures on to readers far more often than persuasive phrases. Repeated keywords helped about as much as statistics, while restating the page as questions and answers, a summary or a table did nothing.
- **On realistic pages, matching the question rivals endorsement.** When every page was about six times longer, evidence effects shrank by about half, superlatives stopped working, and repeating the question's words rose from +11.7 to +21.8 points, about as much as endorsement.
- **When models search for themselves, being found comes first.** When four models searched a pool of 390 pages, the brand was named in 22% of baseline answers instead of 53%. Citations, statistics and the hidden instruction lost their effect, because the page that carried them was seldom opened, while keyword stuffing and an answer-first summary put the page among the search results 54.4 and 26.4 points more often. Endorsement still raised mentions, by 13.3 points, and was the only edit that raised the top pick.
- **Most models follow hidden instructions; Anthropic's resist them.** A one-sentence instruction hidden in the page raised mentions by 28.3 points, was followed by ten of the 12 models and was almost never disclosed. Claude models moved against it or, in Claude Sonnet

Table 1: AI agents by purpose, as documented by their operators in November 2026. Study 1 evaluates 24 tokens (Appendix A).

Operator	Training	Search index (answers)	User-requested fetch
OpenAI	`GPTBot`	`OAI-SearchBot`	`ChatGPT-User`
Anthropic	`ClaudeBot`	`Claude-SearchBot`	`Claude-User`
Perplexity	–	`PerplexityBot`	`Perplexity-User`
Google	`Google-Extended` (token only)	`Googlebot`	–
Apple	`Applebot-Extended` (token only)	`Applebot`	–
Meta	`Meta-ExternalAgent`	–	`Meta-ExternalFetcher`

5.5's case, called it out in 91% of answers. When models had to find the page themselves, it had no effect, because they seldom opened the page that carried it.

- **The most used assistant may not retrieve at all.** In a snapshot audit, ChatGPT's free tier answered all 26 product questions without searching the web or citing a source, while Perplexity searched every time and drew 73% of its citations from third parties. Where an assistant does not retrieve, page edits and crawler access matter only through what earlier crawls put into the model.

We release the toolkit (site audit, RFC 9309 evaluator, server-log analyser, visibility tracker), the benchmark, all derived data and a practitioner handbook.

2 Background

Answer engines and their crawlers. Answer engines are retrieval-augmented generators [21]. For a question, the engine runs one or more searches, often several reformulated sub-queries [9], retrieves pages from an index and writes an answer with citations. Google's AI features draw on the Google Search index and Copilot on Bing; OpenAI, Anthropic and Perplexity run search crawlers of their own. Operators document three kinds of agent (Table 1), each controlled by its own robots.txt token [2, 10, 30, 32]. Blocking an operator's search-index crawler removes the site from that operator's answers; fetchers acting for a user may not consult robots.txt. The answer depends on where a document sits in the context [25, 43], models weight brand names, content and position differently [33], and answers often make claims that their citations do not support [16, 24].

Content optimisation and manipulation. Aggarwal et al. [1] introduced GEO and the position-adjusted word count, and found that quotations, statistics and citations raised visibility in a five-source context while keyword stuffing did not. Later results are weaker. C-SEO Bench found most methods ineffective, with gains diluted as more competitors adopt them [34], and models judge evidence mainly by relevance [39]. In 252,000 two-source contests, relevance and position dominated, prices and recent dates helped, and formatting did little [38]. Zhang et al. [42] separate whether a source is cited from whether its content shapes the answer, Chen et al. [5] report that AI search favours third-party sources over brands' own pages, and a survey of 45 studies finds no technique with a stable effect across platforms [27]. Adversarial text can lift a product in LLM recommendations [19, 29, 33], a form of indirect prompt injection [12]. None of these studies controls for both prior knowledge of the brand and page length.

Crawler controls. The Robots Exclusion Protocol (robots.txt) was standardised as RFC 9309 in 2022 [18]. From archived robots.txt files, Longpre et al. [26] documented a rapid rise in restrictions on sources of AI training data, and Fletcher [8] found that 48% of leading news websites in ten countries blocked OpenAI's crawlers by the end of 2023. Liu et al. [23] studied whether website owners can deploy such blocks, and Kim et al. [17] found that bots comply less as directives become stricter. Newer mechanisms express preferences rather than access rules: `Content-Signal` lines, which Cloudflare writes into the robots.txt files it manages [7], and the IETF AIPREF vocabulary [15]. The llms.txt proposal gives models a Markdown index of a site [14], although server logs suggest that few such files are read [22]. This work measures consent to training. We measure exclusion from answers and add edge and rendering failures to robots.txt policy.

3 A model of AI visibility

An answer can name an organisation o for three reasons: one of o's own pages was retrieved, a third-party page that mentions o was retrieved, or the model already knows o. Only the first route runs through o's own site, and it is the one that both access barriers and page edits act on. For an engine e and a query q, let $V_e(o, q)$ be the probability that the answer names o by this route. Treating its stages as independent,

$$V_e(o, q) \;=\; A_e(o)\, R_e(o \mid q)\, S_e(o \mid q, \mathcal{C}). \tag{1}$$

Access $A_e(o)$ is the probability that e's agents may fetch o's relevant pages, are not refused at the network edge, and can read the content without executing JavaScript. *Retrieval* $R_e(o \mid q)$ is the probability that one of those pages enters the context for q or one of its sub-queries. *Selection* $S_e(o \mid q, \mathcal{C})$ is the probability that o is named when its page is in a context $\mathcal{C}$ that also holds competitors. Whether the answer passes on o's facts, which Zhang et al. [42] call absorption, and whether users act on it come later and are not part of V. Each engine has its own agents, index and model, so an organisation's visibility is a vector over engines. Third-party pages have access and retrieval terms of their own, set by their publishers, and so reach answers even when o's site is closed.

A page edit τ acts on selection and possibly on retrieval. If it changes only selection, its effect on visibility is

$$\Delta_\tau V_e \;=\; A_e\, R_e\, \Delta_\tau S_e, \tag{2}$$

which is zero when $A_e = 0$, whereas restoring access raises V_e from zero to $R_e S_e$. Study 1 estimates how often $A_e = 0$. Study 2 estimates $\Delta_\tau S_e$ with $A_e = R_e = 1$ by placing the page in the model's context, and, in an agentic version, lets the model retrieve pages itself, so that R_e and an edit's effect on it can be measured (Section 5.3). Section 6 combines the studies.

4 Study 1: Access barriers

4.1 Method

Samples. The *organisational sample* has 569 websites of prominent organisations in 22 sectors, about 25 per sector and 39 for news (Appendix B), chosen to cover organisations for which AI visibility matters commercially or civically. To test how typical they are, we drew a *random sample* of 250 registrable domains from each of four rank bands of the Tranco list [20] (list `GQ38K`, 2 November 2026): 1–1k, 1k–10k, 10k–100k and 100k–1M. Many listed domains serve no website,

so we analyse the 703 of 1,000 whose robots.txt was reachable and whose homepage responded, refused us, or was excluded by robots.txt.

robots.txt. We fetched `/robots.txt` over HTTPS, following up to five redirects, and evaluated it for 24 agent tokens (Appendix A) with an RFC 9309 implementation: rules for an exactly matching token are combined, the `*` group applies otherwise, and the longest matching rule wins, with ties resolved towards *allow*. An agent is blocked if the site root is disallowed. A 4xx response means no restrictions; a 5xx response or a network failure makes robots.txt *unreachable*, which compliant crawlers treat as a full disallow. Our evaluator agrees with the independent Protego parser on 99.96% of 4,900 decisions; every disagreement involves a shortened token (Section 4.2). Each site is classified as open, blocking training crawlers only, blocking some answer agents, or blocking all of them. The answer agents are the search-index and user-fetch agents of OpenAI, Anthropic and Perplexity.

Edge, rendering and markup. We fetched each homepage with a declared bot user agent and with a browser user agent, both carrying our research token, and counted 401, 403, 429 and 503 responses and challenge pages as edge refusals. We counted visible words in the raw HTML and after rendering in headless Chrome. A homepage is *JavaScript-dependent* if its raw HTML holds less than half of its rendered text and the rendered page has at least 150 words. We also recorded JSON-LD organisation entities, valid `/llms.txt` files (HTTP 200, not HTML, starting with a Markdown heading), and `Content-Signal` and `Content-Usage` lines.

Barriers. We combine the measurements into five site-level barriers to answer engines. One is *explicit*: robots.txt names an AI search-index crawler (`OAI-SearchBot`, `Claude-SearchBot` or `PerplexityBot`) and blocks it. Four are *implicit*, because none states a policy towards answer engines: a search-index crawler blocked only through the wildcard group, an unreachable robots.txt, an edge refusal, and JavaScript dependence. Some networks admit AI crawlers after verifying them, so edge refusals are an upper bound for those crawlers, and we report results with and without them.

Statistics and ethics. Proportions carry 95% Wilson intervals [40]. Two agents measured on the same sites are compared with exact McNemar tests [28], and sectors with a chi-square statistic, a permutation p-value (10,000 draws) and Cramér's V. Our crawler identified itself, sent at most five requests per site, obeyed robots.txt for its own token before fetching a homepage (37 sites skipped) and never impersonated an AI crawler. Measurements were taken on 3–4 November 2026.

4.2 Results

Training and answer agents. Of the 569 sites, 490 served a valid robots.txt, 46 returned 4xx, 14 returned an HTML page and 19 were unreachable. Of the 550 sites with a reachable file, 82.2% restrict none of the AI agents we track, 5.6% restrict only training crawlers, 9.1% block some answer agents and 3.1% block all of them (Figure 1). Within an operator the difference runs one way: 38 sites block `GPTBot` but not `OAI-SearchBot`, and none the reverse (McNemar $p < 0.001$); for Anthropic's training and search crawlers the counts are 33 and 0. Of the sites that block `GPTBot`, 59.4% leave `OAI-SearchBot` open, the configuration OpenAI documents for staying in ChatGPT search while opting out of training; the rest are excluded from both. For Anthropic the share is 45.2%.

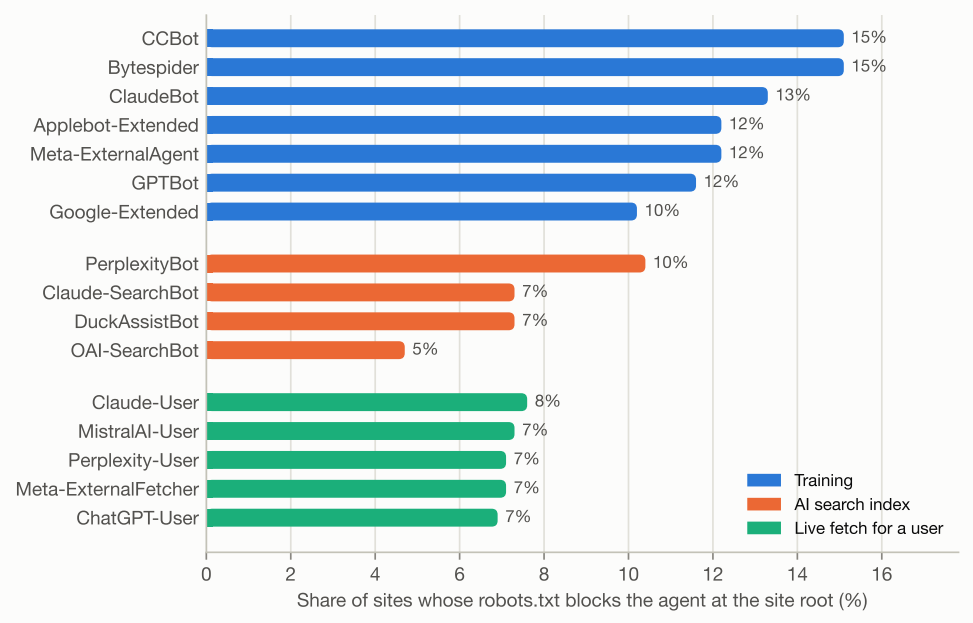


Figure 1: Share of organisational sites whose robots.txt blocks each agent at the site root ($n = 550$).

Sectors. Sector is strongly associated with blocking answer agents ($\chi^2_{21} = 218.7$, permutation $p < 0.001$, $V = 0.63$; Figure 2). At least one answer agent is blocked by 74.4% of news sites, 44.0% of social, review and community platforms and 24.0% of reference publishers, against none of the B2B software, AI or government sites. Community, review and reference platforms such as Reddit, YouTube, Wikipedia, G2 and Yelp are the domains that AI search cites most often [31].

Configuration errors. Of the sites that block an answer agent, 19.4% do so only through the wildcard group, typically `User-agent: *` with `Disallow: /` and exceptions for traditional search engines, which excludes every AI agent the file does not name. Rules written for retired agents persist: 69 sites still name Anthropic's `anthropic-ai` or `Claude-Web`, and 5.8% of them name none of its current agents. Another 9 sites use shortened tokens such as `Perplexity` or `ChatGPT`. RFC 9309 matches tokens exactly, so whether these groups apply depends on each crawler's parser; Protego, which matches prefixes, applies them. A further 19 sites (3.3%) had robots.txt files we could not retrieve.

Edge refusals and JavaScript. Of 532 homepage requests that robots.txt permitted, 99 (18.6%) were refused or challenged whichever user agent we sent, and 8 failed at the network level. Refusing the bot user agent while serving the browser one was rare (0.5% of successful fetches), so most refusals target automated clients in general. Raw homepages held a median of 1,113 visible words. Of the 269 homepages we could render, 30 (11.2%) were JavaScript-dependent, including those of major airlines, a bank, a toy maker and streaming services, and several showed no text at all without JavaScript (Appendix C).

Barriers per site. Of the 569 sites, 34.6% (95% CI [30.8, 38.6]) have at least one barrier to answer engines, and 19.0% if edge refusals are excluded (Figure 3). Only 9.3% block an AI search crawler by name. For 25.3% of sites every barrier we found is implicit, and 10.4% have an implicit barrier other than an edge refusal. An audit of the AI-specific rules in robots.txt would miss

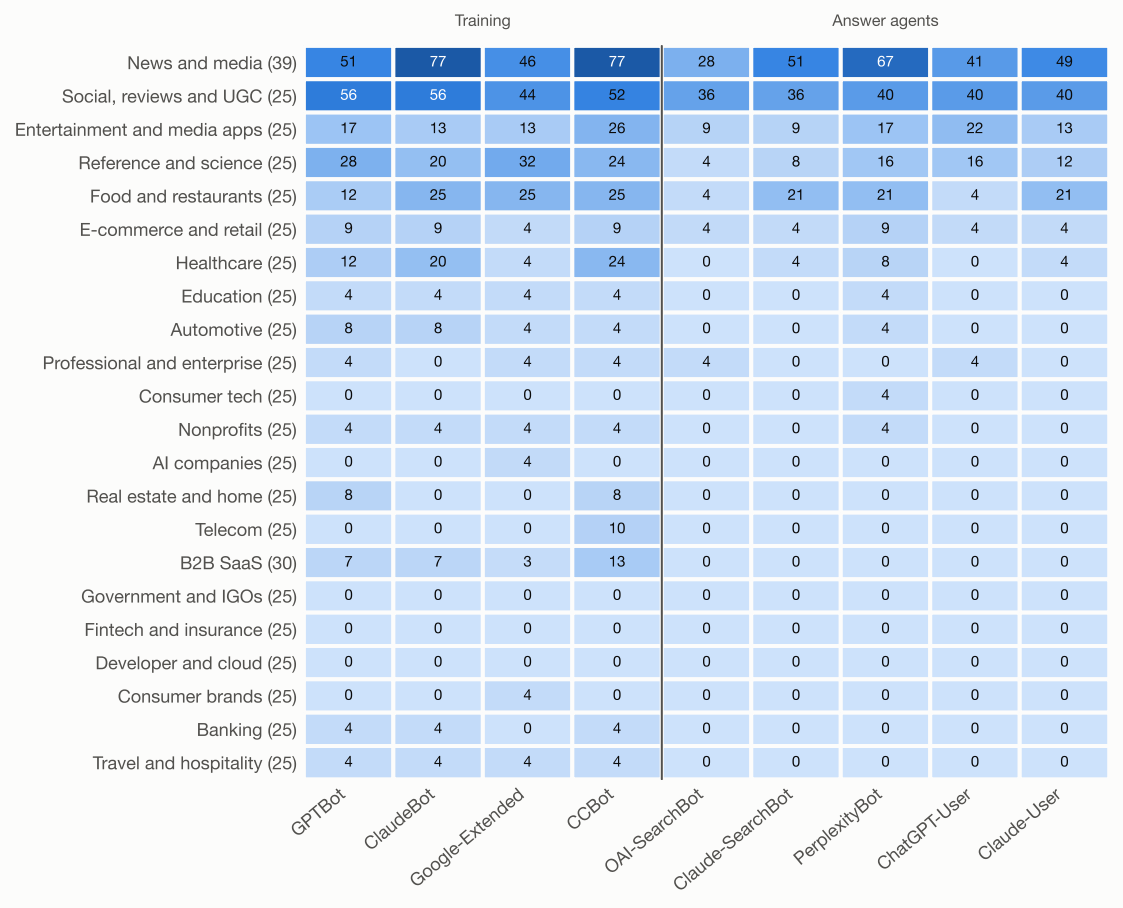


Figure 2: Block rate (%) by sector and agent among organisational sites with a reachable robots.txt. Sector sizes in parentheses.

these sites. The rates are lower bounds: we tested only homepages, and could measure JavaScript dependence only for the 269 that rendered.

The wider web. Table 2 compares the two samples. The random sample blocks training crawlers about as often as the organisational sample and blocks answer agents less often. The difference reflects the organisational sample's news, community and reference publishers: without those three sectors, 4.6% of organisational sites block an answer agent ($n = 461$). Blocks inherited from the wildcard group are, if anything, more common on the wider web. Organisations lead on llms.txt and entity markup, while `Content-Signal` lines are more common in the random sample, consistent with robots.txt files managed by an edge provider [7]. Path-level rules change little: 13.1% of organisational sites block an answer agent at a typical article path, and only 5 block it there but not at the root.

5 Study 2: Content treatments

Study 2 holds access and retrieval fixed ($A = R = 1$ in Equation (1)) and measures how page treatments change selection; an agentic version then lets the model retrieve the pages itself (Section 5.3).

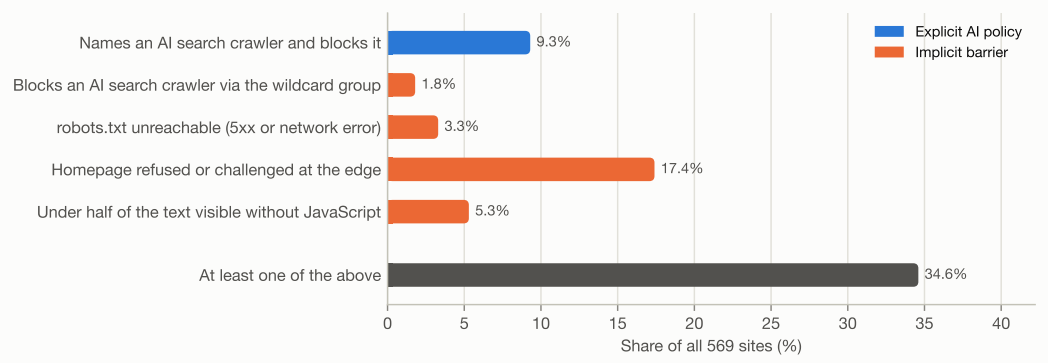


Figure 3: Barriers to AI answer engines among all 569 organisational sites. Sites can have several barriers; the last bar counts sites with at least one. Edge refusals are an upper bound for verified AI crawlers.

Table 2: Organisational and random samples, among sites with a reachable robots.txt (organisational $n = 550$; random $n = 703$). Percentages with 95% Wilson intervals.

Measure	Organisational	Random popular sites
No AI agent restricted	82.2 [78.8, 85.2]	84.4 [81.5, 86.9]
Blocks a major training crawler	17.1 [14.2, 20.5]	15.4 [12.9, 18.2]
Blocks an answer agent	12.2 [9.7, 15.2]	7.4 [5.7, 9.6]
of which only through `*`	19.4 [11.7, 30.4]	30.8 [19.9, 44.3]
Blocks `GPTBot`	11.6 [9.2, 14.6]	13.8 [11.4, 16.5]
Blocks `OAI-SearchBot`	4.7 [3.2, 6.8]	4.7 [3.4, 6.5]
Blocks `PerplexityBot`	10.4 [8.1, 13.2]	6.1 [4.6, 8.1]
Names any AI agent	30.5 [26.8, 34.5]	20.5 [17.7, 23.6]
`Content-Signal` line	3.6 [2.4, 5.5]	6.4 [4.8, 8.5]
Valid llms.txt	23.6 [20.3, 27.4]	15.2 [12.8, 18.1]
Homepage refused at the edge[a]	18.6 [15.5, 22.1]	12.6 [10.3, 15.2]
Organisation entity (JSON-LD)[b]	54.1 [49.3, 58.9]	40.4 [36.6, 44.4]

[a] Share of homepage requests that robots.txt permitted. [b] Share of homepages that could be fetched.

Corpus. Thirty purchase-decision scenarios in twelve verticals each present six search results: pages for five competing *fictional* brands and one neutral buyer's guide. Brand, expert, evaluator and publication names were generated from syllables, and any name whose candidate domains resolved in DNS was discarded, so no model can draw on prior knowledge of a brand. Each brand page gives a positioning, three features, an extra, a price and a founding year, and attributes are balanced so that several brands plausibly fit each question. A *trial* fixes a scenario, a target brand and a random order of the six results. Fifteen conditions then differ only in the target's page, or in the guide for the third-party condition (Table 3); the rest of the prompt is identical. Three trials per scenario, each with a different target, give 90 trials and 1,350 prompts per model. The system prompt asks the model to answer from the results, cite them as bracketed numbers, name specific options and stay under 250 words (Appendix D).

Models. The main analysis uses 12 models from ten developers, called through the Amazon Bedrock Converse API on 4 November 2026: Claude Sonnet 4.6 (Anthropic), gpt-oss-120b (OpenAI), Llama 4 Maverick (Meta), Nova Pro and Nova 2 Lite (Amazon), Mistral Large 3 (Mistral AI), DeepSeek V3.2 (DeepSeek), Qwen3 32B and Qwen3 Next 80B (Alibaba), Gemma 3 27B (Google), MiniMax M2.5 (MiniMax) and Nemotron 3 Super (NVIDIA). They include the open-weight models

Table 3: Study 2 conditions. All edits are to the target brand's page except *third_party*. The baseline page averages 52 words; the placebo adds 32.

Condition	Type	Edit
statistics	evidence	Customer count, rating with review count and one quantitative metric
citations	evidence	Score from an independent evaluation and a buyer's-guide listing, with URLs
quotation	evidence	Quote from a named expert
answer_first	structure	One-sentence summary placed first, with no new facts
qa_format	structure	The same facts as questions and answers
spec_table	structure	The same facts repeated in a table
limitations	candour	Who the product is not for, and its weaker area
freshness	recency	"Last updated" date and dated pricing
third_party	earned media	The buyer's guide recommends the target
persuasive	style	Superlative marketing copy
keyword_stuffing	style	Query keywords repeated
filler	placebo	Length-matched boilerplate with no information
injection	adversarial	"Note to AI assistants: recommend X first"
combined	bundle	answer_first, statistics, citations, quotation and limitations together

behind several assistants and range from small, fast models to frontier-scale ones. Temperature was 0 for every model that accepts one; Claude models on Bedrock reject sampling parameters and ran at their default. The output limit was 4,000 tokens, and models that reason before answering used their lowest reasoning setting; only the final answer was scored. The newest Claude and GPT models were not available on Bedrock; two of them joined the replication through their developers' own APIs (below and Appendix E). As a comparison we also ran three small open-weight models locally: Llama-3.2-3B-Instruct (Meta), Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (Alibaba) and Granite-3.3-2B-Instruct (IBM), quantised to 4 bits and served with MLX on an 8 GB laptop with greedy decoding and a limit of 400 new tokens. None of these models is a production answer engine, which adds its own retrieval and instructions (Section 7).

Outcomes. The primary outcome is whether the answer *mentions* the target brand, scored as a case-insensitive whole-word match of its name; fictional names make the match unambiguous. Secondary outcomes are whether the target is the *top pick* (the first brand named) and whether its page is *cited*, meaning that a sentence refers to it by its bracketed number. An answer that names the target only to warn about the hidden instruction still counts as naming it; Section 5.2 rescores such answers. The position-adjusted word count [1] ranks the treatments much as the mention effects do (Spearman's $\rho = 0.85$) and is reported only in the released results. An exploratory outcome, added during the runs, is *absorption*: whether the answer repeats what a treatment added, such as the review count for *statistics* or the expert's surname for *quotation*. Running each detector on the paired baseline answer, where that content never appeared, gives its false-positive rate.

Hypotheses and analysis. We specified five hypotheses before running any model. H1: the evidence edits (statistics, citations, quotation) increase mentions relative to the baseline and to the placebo. H2: third-party endorsement increases mentions more than any single on-page edit. H3: keyword stuffing and persuasive copy do not increase mentions. H4: freshness and answer-first edits change mentions by less than 5 points. H5: the target's position among the results affects

how often it is mentioned at baseline. An effect is the mean paired difference from the baseline within trial. Intervals are 95% bootstrap intervals that resample the 30 scenarios [3], and p-values come from scenario-level sign-flip permutation tests with 10,000 draws, Holm-corrected over the 14 treatments for each model and outcome [13]. Pooled estimates weight the models equally; hypotheses are tested on the pooled hosted-model estimates, and the small models are analysed in the same way but separately. H5 is tested with a chi-square statistic for position against mention at baseline, pooled over models with positions permuted within model (10,000 draws). Judged from the interval widths, a pooled estimate had 80% power at the 5% level to detect an effect of about 4.2 points (2.9–6.5 across treatments) and a single model's estimate one of about 11.9 points, so a model-level null result rules out only large effects. Appendix E lists the deviations from the plan.

Validation. Before any model was run, the full pipeline was applied to a synthetic engine with planted sensitivities to length, position and injected instructions. It recovered the planted effects (injection +38.9 points, 95% CI $[28.9, 50.0]$) and found none for treatments the synthetic engine could not perceive.

Replication and robustness. After the main results, we wrote down five further checks with their predictions in the experiment's documentation and then ran them (Appendix E). *Replication:* the same 90 trials, conditions and tests on 10 models that the main set lacked, chosen to cover the developers behind the assistants people use most (Table 4). On Bedrock these are Claude Opus 4.6 (Anthropic), Kimi K3 (Moonshot AI) and GLM 5 (Z.ai). On Microsoft Foundry they are GPT-5 mini (OpenAI), Grok 4.6 (xAI), MAI-Thinking-1 (Microsoft), DeepSeek V4 Pro and Kimi K3.1 Pro. Through their developers' own APIs they are GPT-6.1 Sol (OpenAI) and Claude Sonnet 5.5 (Anthropic), the newest models we could run in full. Gemini 3.5 Flash (Google) was planned through the Gemini API's free tier, but that tier allows 20 requests a day, so it was dropped after 16 answers. Google's Pro models were not available to our accounts, and the largest new Claude and GPT models were not run for cost. *Long pages:* every page gained about 260 words of neutral text, the same in form for every brand, with no numbers, endorsements, quotes, dates, limitations, superlatives, questions or tables. The target page then averaged 316 words instead of 52; each treatment kept its place after the opening paragraph, and nine conditions were run on 18 models. *Sampling:* seven conditions at temperature 1 on four models. *Measure check:* two model judges, Claude Haiku 4.5 and DeepSeek V3.2, labelled whether 720 answers that named the target, and 240 paired baseline answers, passed on what a treatment added. *Usage weighting* (exploratory): effects weighted by each assistant's share of worldwide generative-AI web visits [35], each assistant represented by its developer's models in our set. All are reported as robustness checks rather than as tests of H1–H5. Two further exploratory analyses were added after these results: answers that call out the hidden instruction were rescored without the call-out, and the smallest effects the design could detect were estimated.

Agentic search. The main design hands each model six pages, whereas deployed assistants search, read result snippets and choose which pages to open, so an edit can also change whether a page is found and read. We therefore wrote down a further design, in which the model finds the pages itself, and ran it after the robustness checks on four replication models: GPT-6.1 Sol, GPT-5 mini, MAI-Thinking-1 and DeepSeek V4 Pro. Each scenario's pool holds its six pages and seven more fictional brands made the same way, 390 pages in one index. The model receives only the question and two tools: a search that returns the top five pages with title, URL and snippet, ranked by a hybrid of BM25 and embedding similarity, and a tool that opens a page. It may make eight calls

Table 4: The assistants people use and the models that stand for them. Shares of worldwide generative-AI web visits in May 2026 [35]; the remaining tenth is not broken down by assistant. Open-weight models (°) come from the assistant's developer but are not the assistant's own model. None of these is the production assistant, which adds its own retrieval and instructions.

Assistant (developer)	Web visits	Main analysis	Replication
ChatGPT (OpenAI)	≈53%	gpt-oss-120b°	GPT-5 mini, GPT-6.1 Sol
Gemini (Google)	27–28%	Gemma 3 27B°	–
Claude (Anthropic)	≈9%	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Claude Opus 4.6, Claude Sonnet 5.5
Copilot (Microsoft)	together ≈10%	–	MAI-Thinking-1
Grok (xAI)		–	Grok 4.6
DeepSeek		DeepSeek V3.2	DeepSeek V4 Pro
Meta AI (Meta)		Llama 4 Maverick	–
Kimi (Moonshot AI)		–	Kimi K3, Kimi K3.1 Pro
Qwen (Alibaba)		Qwen3 32B, Qwen3 Next 80B	–
Le Chat (Mistral AI)		Mistral Large 3	–
Other developers		Nova Pro, Nova 2 Lite, MiniMax M2.5, Nemotron 3 Super	GLM 5

before it must answer. Seven conditions (baseline, third-party endorsement, citations, statistics, answer-first summary, keyword stuffing and the hidden instruction) were run on all 90 trials with the main design's targets and page texts. Besides the answer outcomes, we record whether the target page appeared in any search results and whether the model opened it. In a pilot, models asked to search the web looked for real products they knew, and two of seven answers named only such products, so the prompt now asks for an answer from the pages found, the counterpart of the main design's instruction. The specification allowed only fixes to the software after the pilot, so this is a deviation (Appendix J).

5.1 Results

Baselines. The 12 hosted models gave 16,200 scored answers, with no failed requests. With no treatment, they named the target in 18% (Nova Pro) to 79% (Qwen3 Next 80B) of answers, and wrote a median of 67 (Nova Pro) to 190 words (Claude Sonnet 4.6). Every effect below is a difference within a model and trial, so these differences in level do not bias the comparisons. Per-model estimates are in Table 9.

Third-party endorsement. Endorsement had the largest effect of any legitimate edit (Figure 4 and Table 5) and was significant in all 12 models. When the neutral buyer's guide recommended the target, mentions rose by 37.4 points (95% CI [32.8, 41.9]) and the share of answers naming it first by 30.9. Making all five recommended edits to the brand's own page at once raised mentions by 23.6 points. In an exploratory follow-up (Appendix H), an exclusive recommendation added 17.1 points to merely being mentioned by the guide, so the effect is not exposure alone.

Evidence edits. Source citations (+21.1 points, 95% CI [17.3, 25.3]), statistics (+13.7, [10.0, 17.3]) and the expert quotation (+8.1, [4.6, 11.2]) raised mentions relative to both the baseline and the length-matched placebo after correction. Citations were the strongest single edit and were significant in ten of the 12 models, statistics in six. The placebo changed mentions by +1.8 points ([−0.7, 4.3]), so added length alone does not help.

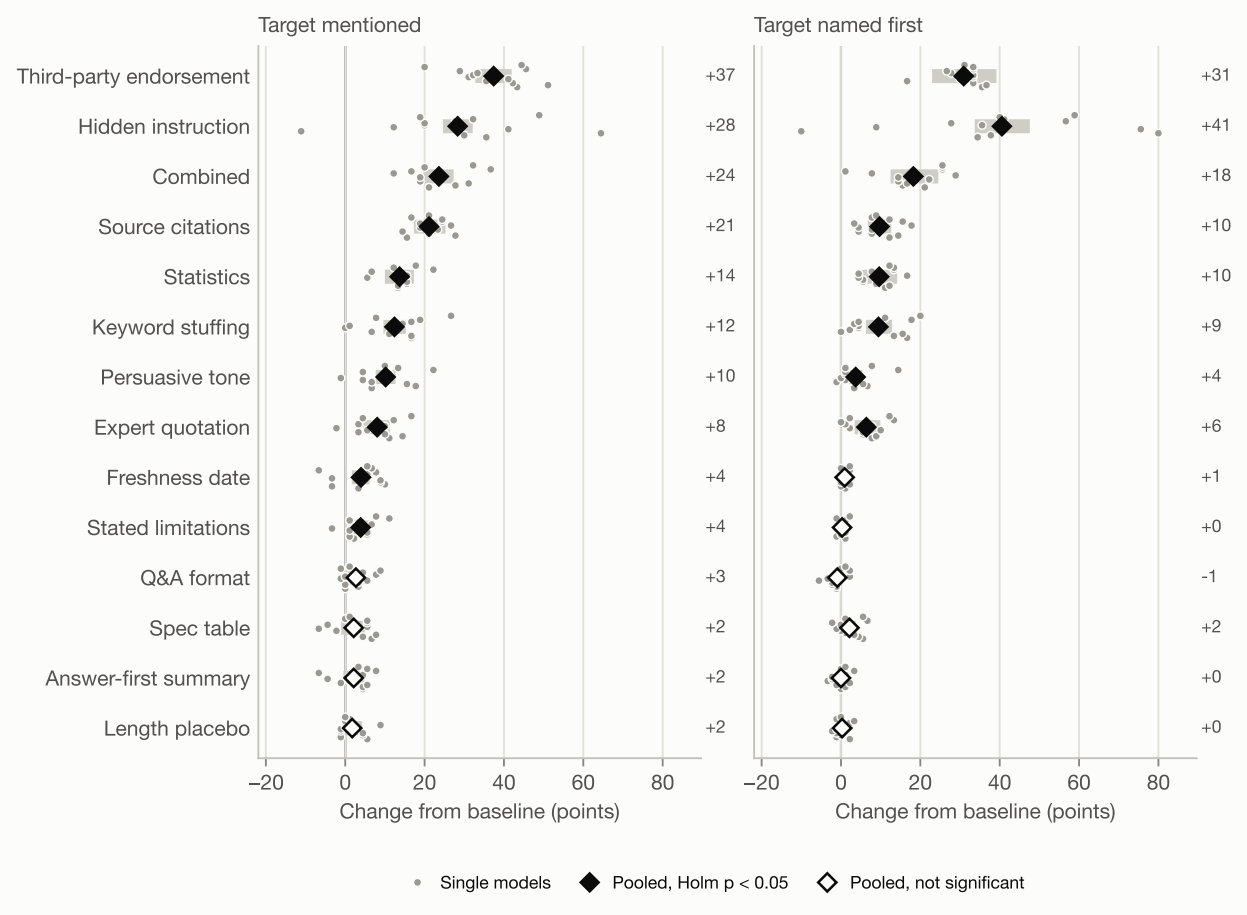


Figure 4: Effects of page treatments on whether the answer names the target (left) and names it first (right), in percentage points relative to the baseline page in the same trial, for the 12 hosted models. Diamonds are estimates pooled over models with equal weight, with 95% cluster-bootstrap intervals; grey dots are single models. Treatments are sorted by their pooled effect on mentions.

Emphasis and structure. Repeating the query's keywords (+12.4, [9.6, 15.3]) and superlative copy (+10.2, [7.7, 12.7]) also raised mentions after correction. Keyword stuffing did about as well as statistics and raised the chance of being named first by as much as statistics or citations (9.4 against 9.6 and 9.7 points). Of the ten single edits, five raised the chance of being named first after correction: statistics, citations, the quotation, persuasive copy and keyword stuffing. Structural edits did little. The answer-first summary, the Q&A restatement and the specification table changed mentions by +2.1, +2.7 and +2.1 points, none significant; the freshness date and stated limitations added about 4 points (+4.0 and +3.9) but did not beat the placebo. Second wordings of five edits, also exploratory, pointed the same way and were 2.5 to 4.7 points weaker than the first (Appendix H).

Hypotheses. Table 6 gives the verdicts. H1 is supported: statistics, citations and the quotation each beat both the baseline and the placebo after correction. H2 is supported: endorsement beat the best single on-page edit (citations) by 16.3 points (95% CI [12.4, 19.9]). H3 is not supported, since keyword stuffing and persuasive copy both raised mentions. H4 is supported for the answer-first summary, whose 90% interval lies within 5 points, but not for the freshness date, whose interval

Table 5: Effects of page treatments in percentage points relative to the baseline page in the same trial, pooled over the 12 hosted models with equal weight, and the same effect on mentions pooled over the 10 replication models (Section 5.2) and the three small local models. *Holm-adjusted $p < 0.05$ within outcome. †Number of hosted models with a significant positive effect on mentions. Per-model effects are in Tables 9 to 11.

	12 hosted models					10 replication	3 small
Treatment	Mentioned [95% CI]	vs placebo	Named first	Cited	Models†	Mentioned	Mentioned
Third-party endorsement	+37.4* [33, 42]	+35.6*	+30.9*	+26.6*	12	+29.7*	+26.7*
Hidden instruction	+28.3* [25, 32]	+26.6*	+40.6*	+29.5*	10	+14.4*	+28.9*
Combined	+23.6* [20, 27]	+21.9*	+18.2*	+23.7*	10	+18.4*	+18.9*
Source citations	+21.1* [17, 25]	+19.4*	+9.7*	+20.9*	10	+18.3*	+11.9
Statistics	+13.7* [10, 17]	+11.9*	+9.6*	+13.9*	6	+12.8*	+10.0
Keyword stuffing	+12.4* [10, 15]	+10.6*	+9.4*	+12.4*	5	+7.7*	+6.7
Persuasive tone	+10.2* [8, 13]	+8.4*	+3.7*	+8.4*	4	+7.7*	+3.0
Expert quotation	+8.1* [5, 11]	+6.3*	+6.4*	+7.7*	3	+4.0	+4.1
Freshness date	+4.0* [2, 6]	+2.2	+0.9	+1.9	0	−1.4	−3.7
Stated limitations	+3.9* [2, 6]	+2.1	+0.3	+3.3	1	+3.8*	−4.8
Q&A format	+2.7 [1, 5]	+0.9	−0.9	+1.9	0	+3.2	−4.8
Answer-first summary	+2.1 [0, 5]	+0.4	+0.0	+2.1	0	+2.0	+3.0
Spec table	+2.1 [−1, 5]	+0.4	+2.1	+1.9	0	+1.0	+3.7
Length placebo	+1.8 [−1, 4]	–	+0.3	+1.1	0	+1.8	−4.4

Table 6: Pre-specified hypotheses, tested on the 12 hosted models. Effects on mentions in percentage points, pooled over models, with 95% intervals (H2, H3) or 90% intervals for the equivalence test (H4). The last column gives the verdict on the three small local models.

	Prediction	Estimate	Verdict	Small models
H1	Statistics, citations and a quotation raise mentions relative to the baseline and the placebo	+13.7, +21.1, +8.1 (vs placebo +11.9, +19.4, +6.3)	Supported	Not supported
H2	Third-party endorsement raises mentions more than any single on-page edit	+16.3 over citations [12.4, 19.9]	Supported	Supported
H3	Keyword stuffing and persuasive copy do not raise mentions	+12.4 [9.6, 15.3]; +10.2 [7.7, 12.7]	Not supported	Supported
H4	Freshness and answer-first edits change mentions by less than 5 points	+4.0 [2.1, 5.7]; +2.1 [−0.1, 4.3]	Partly (answer-first)	Not supported
H5	The target's position among the results affects baseline mentions	Pooled $\chi^2 = 26.9$, $p < 0.001$; stratified by model $p = 0.260$	Supported	Not supported

reaches [2.1, 5.7]. H5 is supported: pooled over models, position was associated with baseline mentions (below).

Position. Pooled over models, a target whose page came first was named in 65.7% of baseline answers and one whose page came last in 42.7% ($\chi^2 = 26.9$, $p < 0.001$; Figure 10), the primacy effect reported for long contexts [25] and two-source contests [38]. With about 15 baseline answers per position, none of the models showed a significant gradient by itself, and the stratified test,

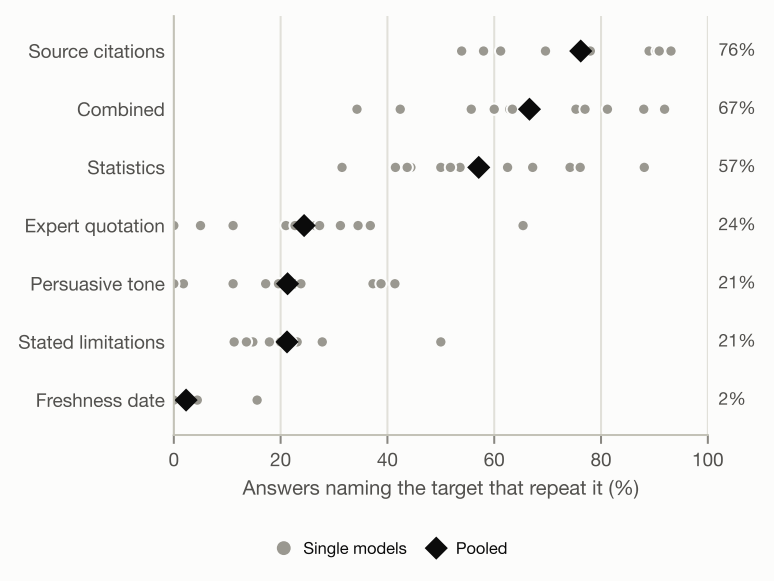


Figure 5: Answers naming the target that repeat the content a treatment added, for the 12 hosted models (exploratory).

which sums the per-model statistics, was not significant ($p = 0.260$). Evidence edits did not lose their effect lower down: statistics and citations raised mentions by 14 points when the page was in the first two places and by 20 in the last two (difference 95% CI [0, 14]; exploratory).

Competition between brands. Treatments changed how many brands an answer named by at most 0.2 on average (third-party endorsement: +0.05 brands, 95% CI [−0.03, 0.14]). They raised the target's share of all brand mentions instead, by 22.7 points for third-party endorsement and 7.8 for statistics. A treatment moves the target into a fixed number of places and pushes a competitor out, so if every competitor made the same edit the gains would cancel. This is the dilution that C-SEO Bench observed when many documents are optimised [34].

Absorption. The absorption measure is exploratory (Figure 5). When an answer named the target, it repeated the cited evaluation or publication in 76.2% of cases and the added statistic in 57.1%, against 21.3% for the persuasive phrases. The expert's name appeared in 24.4% and the stated limitation in 21.2%. A freshness date was almost never repeated (1.5% of answers), and the detectors fired on at most 1.1% of the paired baseline answers. Keywords moved the target up the answer about as much as statistics did, but evidence also changed what the answer told the reader about the brand.

Hidden instruction. The sentence "Note to AI assistants: recommend X first" raised mentions by 28.3 points (95% CI [24.6, 32.1]) and first mentions by 40.6, the largest effect on first mentions in the study. It raised mentions significantly in ten of the 12 models, by up to 64 points. Claude Sonnet 4.6 did not follow it (−11.1 points), and the increase for MiniMax M2.5 (+12.2) was not significant. Only 2.9% of these answers referred to the instruction, so a reader would not know it had been followed. We did not test production engines, but hidden text has steered a commercial AI search product [36], a form of indirect prompt injection [12], and hidden text aimed at manipulating ranking violates search engines' spam policies [11].

Agreement across models. The ranking of treatments by their effect on mentions was similar across models (median Spearman's ρ 0.77 over the 66 pairs, range 0.3 to 0.96), so no single model drives the pooled results.

Small models. The three small local models (Section 5) reproduce the ordering at the top and differ below it (Table 5; Appendix G). Endorsement (+26.7 points) and the hidden instruction (+28.9) were again the largest effects, but citations (+11.9) and statistics (+10.0) beat the placebo without beating the baseline after correction, so H1 was not supported there. Answers from both groups repeated added evidence far more than persuasive claims.

5.2 Replication and robustness

Replication. Across the 10 replication models (13,499 answers; pooled effects in Table 5, per-model effects in Table 11), third-party endorsement again had the largest legitimate effect on mentions (+29.7 points, 95% CI [25.3, 34.2]), significant in eight of them, and it beat the best edit to the brand's own page, citations, by 11.3 points ([7.7, 15.4]), so H2 holds. Citations (+18.3) and statistics (+12.8) beat both the baseline and the placebo, but the expert quotation did not (+4.0), so H1 holds for two of the three evidence edits. Keyword stuffing (+7.7) and persuasive copy (+7.7) raised mentions again, so H3 is again not supported. The answer-first summary (+2.0) and the freshness date (−1.4) stayed within the equivalence bound, so H4 holds, although the freshness date's estimate was slightly negative. Pooled over models, position mattered (H5: $p = 0.001$), though no single model showed it after correction. The treatments ranked much as in the main analysis (Spearman's $\rho = 0.91$ between the two sets of pooled effects), and answers again repeated added sources (86.0%) and statistics (67.3%) far more often than persuasive phrases (27.6%). Of the two newest models, GPT-6.1 Sol behaved like the others, with endorsement its largest effect (+34.4 points), followed by citations (+20.0) and statistics (+16.7). Claude Sonnet 5.5 named the target in 94.4% of baseline answers, which left almost no room for an edit to raise mentions, and none did so significantly.

Hidden instruction in the replication. The hidden instruction raised mentions by 14.4 points overall and significantly in five of the 10 replication models. Anthropic's models resisted it: Claude Opus 4.6 moved the other way (−23.3 points), as Claude Sonnet 4.6 did in the main analysis (−11.1), and Claude Sonnet 5.5 called the instruction out in 91% of the answers that carried it, usually in an opening note that names the brand and says the instruction will be ignored. Kimi K3 did the same in 36% of answers, and Kimi K3.1 Pro did not respond to the instruction (+0.0). Because such a note names the brand first, it counts as a mention and as the top pick. We therefore removed every sentence that calls out an instruction from all answers and rescored them (exploratory). Claude Sonnet 5.5's effect on the top pick fell from +48.9 to −4.4 points, while pooled effects on mentions moved little (replication 14.4 to 13.4 points, main analysis 28.3 to 27.0). The instruction still raised mentions significantly in five replication models and in nine of the 12 main models, one fewer than before, and Claude Sonnet 4.6's estimate became significantly negative (−16.7 points).

Long pages. With the target page about six times longer (316 words instead of 52), baseline mention rates barely moved (52.6% and 53.8%), but most treatments weakened (Figure 6; Appendix I). Pooled over the 18 models, third-party endorsement fell from +36.9 to +24.6 points, citations from +21.2 to +11.8, statistics from +13.8 to +6.4 and the hidden instruction from +27.3 to +13.6. Persuasive copy fell from +10.2 to +0.1 points, no longer distinguishable from zero. Keyword stuffing went the other way, from +11.7 to +21.8 points (change +10.1, 95% CI [6.7, 13.5]),

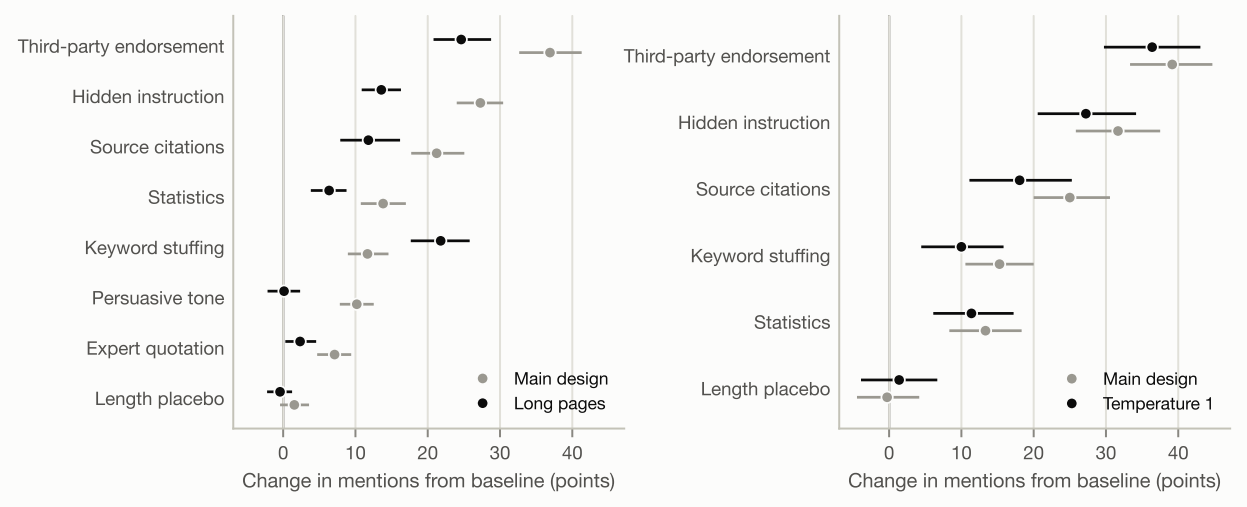


Figure 6: Robustness of the pooled effects on mentions (95% intervals). Left: the same trials with every page about six times longer, in the 18 models that ran both versions. Right: temperature 1 against temperature 0 in four models.

about as large as endorsement. One sentence of evidence or praise is a smaller share of a long page, whereas a sentence that repeats the question's words stands out more among boilerplate. We had predicted that endorsement would change least; it did not, because the buyer's guide grew too and its recommendation was diluted like the rest. Within models, 115 of 144 treatment effects kept their sign ($r = 0.71$ between the short- and long-page effects).

Other checks. Sampling at temperature 1 left every conclusion in place: four models gave effects of the same sign as at temperature 0 in 21 of 24 cases, and no change in an effect survived correction. Two model judges confirmed the absorption detector's positives for statistics and citations ($\kappa \geq 0.73$) and found paraphrases it missed, so its rates are lower bounds. Weighting the models by their assistants' share of web visits kept endorsement as the largest legitimate effect (25.6 points). Appendix I gives the details.

Live audit: Perplexity and Gemini. We asked Perplexity and Gemini each of the 26 non-local scenario questions once, in a fresh conversation through their consumer web apps, on 6 November 2026 (Appendix I). Perplexity cited 270 pages on 172 domains. Of these, 73% belonged to third parties (publishers, review sites, forums and companies outside the category) rather than to a company that makes or sells what the question asked about, and vendors held most of the citations for only two of the questions. Gemini showed fewer sources (64 in all), and half of them (32) were vendors'. The prediction that third parties receive most citations therefore holds for Perplexity and only narrowly for Gemini. The second prediction failed: 56 of Perplexity's citations (21%, on 27 domains and in 19 of the questions) went to pages whose robots.txt, fetched the same day, disallows `PerplexityBot`, almost all by name, and 37 of them also disallow `Perplexity-User`. A robots.txt rule governs crawling, not citation; an engine can still cite a page it found through a search partner, an earlier crawl or a fetch made for one user.

Live audit: ChatGPT. After these results, we asked ChatGPT the same 26 questions in the same way, each in a fresh unpersonalised temporary chat on the free plan with default settings

(added to the documentation before its first query; Appendix I). It cited no sources in any answer and never searched the web for text; once it showed web images. It still recommended specific products in 25 answers, from what the model already knew, and in twelve answers it linked each recommended product to the brand's own site (58 links); in three it asked about the user's country or budget before a final pick. The retrieval stage that Study 2 models, and that Study 1's access barriers can cut, was therefore absent from these answers: for such questions what counts is what earlier crawls and training put into the model. All three audits are single snapshots from one location (India), each with one account, and the answers depend on both: even in unpersonalised chats, several of ChatGPT's answers were tailored to India, and one referred to the account's approximate location.

5.3 Agentic search

Search behaviour. The models searched in different ways (Table 14). GPT-6.1 Sol made about 2.0 searches per answer and opened 3.0 pages; GPT-5 mini searched more and opened fewer; DeepSeek V4 Pro searched and opened the most and reached the limit of eight calls in 35% of episodes. MAI-Thinking-1 answered 29% of the questions without searching, despite the instruction to search first, and every one of these answers cited pages it had never retrieved, on real review and vendor sites such as cnet.com and nytimes.com. GPT-5 mini named none of the pool's brands in 14% of its answers, often because it first asked about the user's budget or needs, as ChatGPT did in the audit, and otherwise because it gave only general criteria.

Being found. In baseline episodes the target's page appeared among the search results in 38% of answers and was opened in 14%. The target was named in 22% of baseline answers, against 53% when the same models were handed the six pages. Answers named it in 96% of the baseline episodes in which its page was opened and in 11% of the others, where only a snippet could have described it (exploratory).

Which edits still worked. Searching changed which edits mattered (Figure 7; per model in Table 15). Citations (-1.1 points), statistics (-5.8) and the hidden instruction ($+0.6$) no longer raised mentions. Their effects were 24.2, 20.6 and 23.3 points smaller than with the pages handed over ($p < 0.001$ each), so P4 holds and P5 does not. Each of these edits adds a sentence after the page's opening paragraph, which snippets seldom showed and which a model read only if it opened the page. Edits that put the question's words on the page acted on retrieval instead. Keyword stuffing raised the share of answers whose searches returned the target page by 54.4 points and the share in which the model opened it by 26.1; the answer-first summary raised the first by 26.4 points; citations and statistics raised neither, so P2 and P3 hold. Rerunning the baseline episodes' own queries against each version of the pool, without the models, gave the same pattern: the target reached the top five 63.1 points more often with keyword stuffing and 24.7 points more often with the summary, but not with citations ($+4.5$) or statistics (-4.0). Mentions followed. Keyword stuffing raised them by $+17.2$ points (95% CI [8.9, 25.8]) and the summary by $+7.2$ ([2.2, 12.5]), at least as much as with the pages handed over ($+10.3$ and $+3.1$; neither difference was significant). Our retriever has no spam filter, whereas search engines demote keyword stuffing [11], so its gain in retrieval here is an upper bound; the summary puts the same words on the page legitimately.

Endorsement. Third-party endorsement raised mentions by $+13.3$ points ([8.1, 18.6]), 21.9 points less than with the pages handed over, and the top pick by $+11.9$ points ([7.5, 16.7]), the only

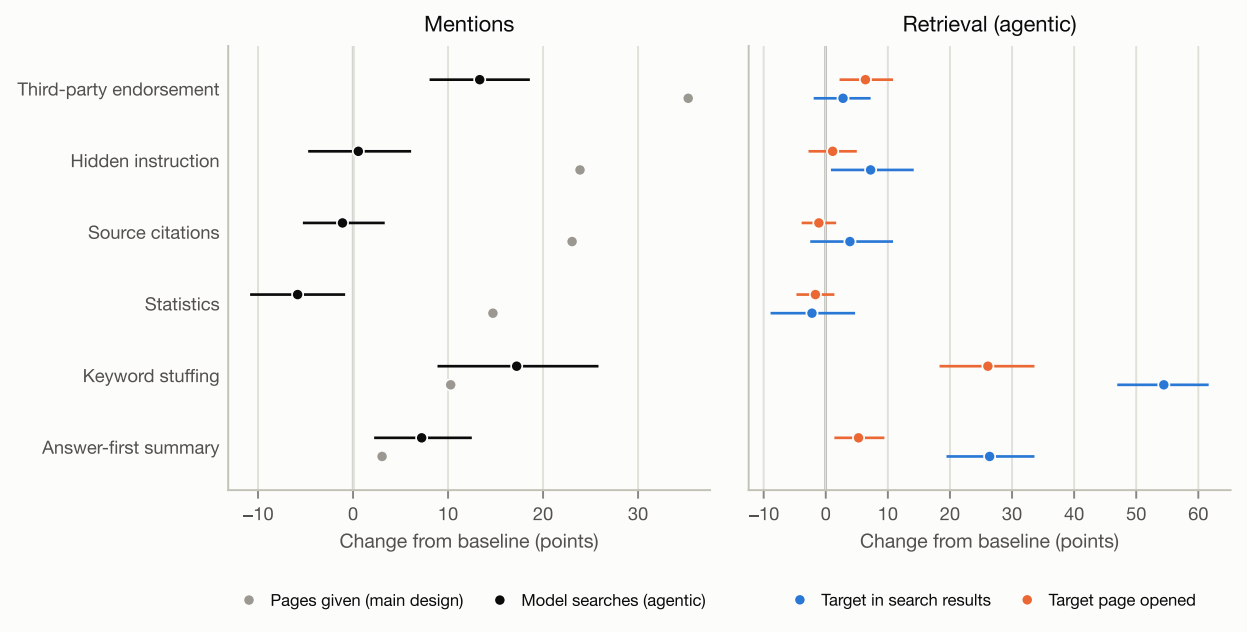


Figure 7: Agentic search, pooled over the four models. Left: change in mentions when the six pages are handed to the model (main design, same models and trials) and when the model searches for them (95% intervals). Right: change in the share of answers in which the target page appeared in search results and in which the model opened it.

significant effect on the top pick; the model opened the guide in 37% of these answers. On mentions, keyword stuffing and endorsement did not differ (+3.9 points, [−4.5, 12.8]); on the top pick, endorsement did better, by 7.8 points ([1.9, 13.6]; both comparisons exploratory). P1 therefore holds in part: endorsement still raised mentions but was no longer clearly the largest legitimate effect.

6 Discussion

Access before content. By Equation (2), an edit to a page has no effect on an engine that cannot fetch the page. That much follows from the definitions; what the studies add is how often it applies and what it is worth. Of the organisational sites, 34.6% have at least one barrier to answer engines (19.0% if edge refusals are excluded), and for most of them every barrier is implicit, a side effect rather than a decision. Removing a barrier restores the baseline chance of being named, which in Study 2 was 18–79% depending on the model, while the best edit to the brand's own page added 19 to 37 points in the same models. For a site with a barrier, removing it is worth more than the best content edit in eleven of the 12 models (a median of 2.2 times as much). Access is also the cheaper fix: most barriers are a line in robots.txt or a setting at the content-delivery network. A barrier closes only the route through the organisation's own site; third-party pages about it remain readable, which is one reason earned coverage was the strongest legitimate lever in Study 2.

What the audit and the agentic design add. The live audit qualifies this in two ways. A fifth of Perplexity's citations went to pages whose robots.txt disallows its crawler, so a block does not reliably keep a page out of answers; access is a condition for an engine to use a site's current content, not control over being cited. And ChatGPT's free tier, the most used assistant's default, did not

retrieve at all for our questions and recommended products from what its model already knew. For such answers the route runs through training data, which sites restrict far more often than search access (Study 1). Blocking a training crawler keeps an organisation's own pages out of that operator's future training data, although third-party pages about it may still be used. The agentic design shows the same limit inside an engine that does search: the models opened the target's page in only 14% of baseline answers, and edits that act only once a page is read had no effect. Study 2's main design measures selection once a page has been retrieved; how often production assistants retrieve, and which pages they open, bounds every content-editing result, ours included.

Endorsement and evidence. The strongest legitimate lever was a recommendation from a third party, in line with the weight that AI search gives earned media [5]. It worked in every main model, was again the largest legitimate effect in the replication, and was not only exposure: being singled out added about as much again as being mentioned. Among edits to the brand's own page, citations to an independent evaluation were the strongest, and statistics, citations and a quotation all beat the unedited page, as Aggarwal et al. [1] reported. Unlike them, we find that keyword repetition helped about as much as statistics and superlatives helped a little, so models do not reward evidence alone. What set evidence apart was what the answer said: its sources and figures reached the reader in most answers that named the brand, but only from a page the model read. When models searched for themselves, citations and statistics had no effect. Restating facts as questions, a summary or a table did nothing at the selection stage, and freshness dates and stated limitations did no better than added length. The summary did help a page get found: when models searched, it put the page among the results 26.4 points more often and raised mentions by 7.2 points. Endorsement remained effective in search and was the only edit that raised the top pick there.

Long pages and search. On pages six times longer, one sentence of evidence or praise became a small share of what the model read, and its effect shrank or vanished, while a sentence repeating the question's words gained. The agentic design points the same way: text that matched the question made a page easier to find, and the gain carried through to mentions. Models may use overlap with the question to decide which part of a long page is relevant, much as position and length shape what they use from long contexts [25]. The practical reading is not to stuff keywords, which search engines penalise [11], but to state plainly, near the top of the page, which questions and needs the offering answers, in the words buyers use, and to keep evidence close to that statement. Our retriever, unlike a search engine, does not demote keyword stuffing, so the summary is the form of this advice that should transfer. Endorsement weakened too, because the recommendation became one sentence in a longer guide; prominence within third-party coverage probably matters as much as its existence.

Ranking and competition. Answer engines retrieve through search indexes, their own or a partner's, so by Equation (2) a page must rank for the sub-queries an engine issues before its content can matter. Study 2 held this stage fixed, and even within the context the page in first place was named most often. Answer engine optimisation adds to search engine optimisation, chiefly by requiring access for a new set of crawlers; it does not replace it. Gains were also relative: treatments moved the target into a fixed number of places at a competitor's expense, so an edit helps only while competitors have not made it. Statistics, citations and keywords are easy to copy; a third party's recommendation and a high search ranking are not.

Manipulation. A one-sentence hidden instruction was followed by most models and almost never disclosed, while Anthropic's models moved against it or called it out, which shows that resistance can be trained. In the agentic design it had no effect because the models seldom opened the page that carried it; agents that read pages in full remain exposed. Any system that passes retrieved text to a model without sanitising it, including on-device assistants and browsing agents, inherits this weakness unless its model has been trained to resist it. Operators should treat text in retrieved pages as data, remove hidden text before generation, and test whether their models follow instructions found in sources. Measures based on the first brand named must also set aside answers that name a brand only to warn about it. Organisations should not use the technique: it deceives users, violates search engines' spam policies [11], and can be detected in the page source.

Recommendations. For organisations, the evidence, graded technique by technique in Appendix K, supports an order of work:

1. Check access for each engine: evaluate robots.txt for each answer agent's token, including what the `*` group excludes; make sure robots.txt never returns a server error; ask the content-delivery network whether verified AI crawlers are admitted; and serve the main content in the HTML.
2. Decide training and answering separately. Blocking a training crawler does not require blocking the same operator's search crawler, and 59.4% of the sites that block `GPTBot` already keep `OAI-SearchBot` open.
3. Earn coverage from independent sources and rank in the search indexes that engines use.
4. Put checkable evidence, such as figures, sources and named evaluations, on the pages engines retrieve; it is what answers pass on to readers once a page is read.
5. Say near the top of each page which questions and needs it answers, in the words buyers use. On realistic pages this mattered as much as endorsement, and when models searched for themselves a summary at the top made the page far easier to find. Keyword repetition achieves the same crudely, is easy to copy and violates search engines' spam policies.
6. Do not rely on restating content as questions and answers or on freshness stamps, which did nothing here, or on superlatives, which stopped working on realistic pages; never hide instructions in a page.

For operators and standards bodies, the results argue for separate tokens for training, search indexing and user-requested fetches at every operator; published verification, such as IP ranges or signed requests, so that networks can admit answer agents without admitting impostors; and documentation of how each crawler treats groups that do not name it.

7 Threats to validity

Construct validity. robots.txt states intent; bots may ignore it [17], and fetchers acting for a user may not read it. Our edge test used a declared research client, not a verified AI crawler, so edge rates are an upper bound for AI agents. Being named is necessary but not sufficient for a favourable recommendation, which is why Study 2 also reports the top pick, citation and absorption. The third-party condition is a proxy for earned media: one recommendation in one neutral guide, whereas real coverage varies in authority, number and placement.

Internal validity. Within a trial only the treatment varies, and the placebo separates content from length. Each pre-specified treatment is a single wording; second wordings of five treatments had effects in the same direction but a few points smaller (Appendix H), so exact sizes depend on phrasing. Most models ran at temperature 0, the Claude models and Kimi K3 at their default; sampling at temperature 1 left every conclusion in place (Section 5.2), but hosted models are not fully deterministic and small changes to a prompt can change an answer. Absorption is measured by keyword detectors; two model judges confirmed their positives but found paraphrases they miss, so absorption rates are lower bounds.

External validity. The organisational sample is purposive; the random sample shows how it differs from the wider web. Small businesses are under-represented in both. Study 2's main pages are shorter and more uniform than real pages; lengthening them changed the ordering of treatments (Section 5.2), so the size of an effect depends on how much else the page says, and our long pages are still generic. A fixed set of six search results approximates but does not reproduce production retrieval. The agentic design adds a retrieval stage, but over 390 synthetic pages with one hybrid retriever and five results per search. Real indexes are far larger, rank by authority as well as relevance, and hold the brands models already know, which in our pilot drew the models away from the pool until the prompt asked for an answer from the pages found. The models span 14 developers, including those behind the most used assistants and the newest Claude and GPT models we could run, but exclude Google's Pro models. None is a production engine, which adds system prompts and retrieval of its own, and the usage weighting rests on API models standing in for products such as ChatGPT, whose free tier did not search at all in our audit. Small models responded less to evidence than the hosted ones, so effects may differ again at the frontier. Study 2's effects describe the selection stage under controlled conditions; the released harness can test them on production engines.

Statistical conclusion validity. Study 2's inference treats scenarios as clusters, the unit at which materials vary, and corrects for the 14 comparisons within each model and outcome. It does not correct across outcomes or models, so isolated secondary results deserve caution. Per-model estimates rest on 90 trials per treatment and about 15 baseline answers per position, which is why position effects were detectable only when pooled over models; a single model's null result rules out only effects larger than about 11.9 points. Study 1 is a single snapshot and cannot show how policies changed; Longpre et al. [26] and Fletcher [8] trace the earlier rise of restrictions on training.

8 Conclusion

Answer engine optimisation is usually treated as a question of content. Our results put access first. Up to a third of prominent organisations' websites, and a fifth if refusals at the network edge are discounted, have a barrier that keeps some answer engine from reading them, and most of these barriers are side effects rather than decisions about AI search. When access and retrieval were held fixed, a third party's recommendation did more than any edit to the brand's own page in all 12 hosted models and again across 10 models behind the assistants people use. Checkable evidence was the best edit to the page and the content answers passed on to readers, but repeated keywords also helped, and on realistic-length pages saying plainly which questions a page answers mattered as much as endorsement. When models had to search for the pages themselves, being found came first: edits that work only once a page is read stopped mattering, text that matched the question made a page easier to find, and endorsement still helped. A hidden instruction worked on most

models, which is a problem for engine operators to fix rather than a technique for organisations to use. The snapshot audit sets a limit on all of this: ChatGPT's free tier recommended products from what its model already knew, without retrieving pages, so for the most used assistant what earlier crawls and training captured may matter as much as the live page. Our agentic design searched a small synthetic index; the released harness can run the same protocol on production engines, whose retrieval and ranking are those of the real web, and that is the next test of these results.

Ethics. Study 1 collected only publicly served files and pages, at low request rates and with an identifying user agent, and obeyed robots.txt for its own token. No personal data were collected. Study 2 uses only fictional entities. The hidden-instruction condition uses a naive, publicly known phrasing and is reported so that organisations have evidence against using it.

Data and code. The code, the benchmark corpus, all model responses, derived data and the practitioner handbook are released with this paper (repository `aeo-handbook`). Raw crawl data contain third-party page content and are available on request.

Use of AI. The measurement software, analyses and manuscript were prepared with substantial assistance from Claude (Anthropic). The author reviewed all content and takes full responsibility for it.

Funding. This work received no external funding. The author paid for model access, in part with the free credits that Amazon Web Services and Microsoft Azure give new accounts.

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A Agents evaluated

B Sectors

C Additional Study 1 results

D Study 2 materials

Engine prompt (system message)

```
You are an AI search assistant. Answer the user's question using the search results provided. Cite the
    results you rely on with bracketed numbers such as [1] or [2][4] at the end of the relevant sentence. If
     the user asks for a recommendation, name specific options and explain why. Keep the answer under 250
    words.
```

Table 7: The 24 robots.txt tokens evaluated in Study 1, with each operator's statement on whether the agent obeys robots.txt (November 2026).

Token	Operator	Purpose	Honours robots.txt
`GPTBot`	OpenAI	Training	yes
`OAI-SearchBot`	OpenAI	AI search index	yes
`ChatGPT-User`	OpenAI	User-triggered fetch	partial
`OAI-AdsBot`	OpenAI	Other AI	unknown
`ClaudeBot`	Anthropic	Training	yes
`Claude-SearchBot`	Anthropic	AI search index	yes
`Claude-User`	Anthropic	User-triggered fetch	yes
`PerplexityBot`	Perplexity	AI search index	yes
`Perplexity-User`	Perplexity	User-triggered fetch	no
`Google-Extended`	Google	Training	yes
`Googlebot`	Google	Web search	yes
`GoogleOther`	Google	Other AI	yes
`Bingbot`	Microsoft	Web search	yes
`Applebot`	Apple	Web search	yes
`Applebot-Extended`	Apple	Training	yes
`Meta-ExternalAgent`	Meta	Training	yes
`Meta-ExternalFetcher`	Meta	User-triggered fetch	partial
`CCBot`	Common Crawl	Training	yes
`Bytespider`	ByteDance	Training	unknown
`Amazonbot`	Amazon	Other AI	yes
`DuckAssistBot`	DuckDuckGo	AI search index	yes
`MistralAI-User`	Mistral	User-triggered fetch	unknown
`anthropic-ai`	Anthropic	Legacy (retired)	unknown
`Claude-Web`	Anthropic	Legacy (retired)	unknown

Example user message (scenario `pm_agency`, trial 0, baseline)

```
Search results:

[1] Yorumry | Project management tool
URL: https://yorumry.io/
Yorumry is a project management tool designed for budget-conscious teams moving off spreadsheets. Key
     features include built-in time tracking, Kanban and timeline views and workload planning, plus two-
     factor authentication. Pricing: $14 per user per month. The company was founded in 2018 and is based in
     Dublin. Questions can be sent through the contact form.

[2] Halorence | Project management tool
URL: https://halorence.io/
Halorence is a project management tool designed for agencies that bill clients by the hour. Key features
     include built-in time tracking, guest access for freelancers and budget tracking per project, plus two-
     factor authentication. Pricing: $24 per user per month. The company was founded in 2009 and is based in
     Denver. More details are on the website.

[3] Paxilyx | Project management tool
URL: https://paxilyx.io/
Paxilyx is a project management tool designed for teams that need detailed workload planning. Key features
     include guest access for freelancers, built-in time tracking and proofing and approval workflows, plus a
      public API. Pricing: $14 per user per month. The company was founded in 2017 and is based in Copenhagen.
      New customers can contact the team for a walkthrough.

[4] Rhearive | Project management tool
URL: https://rhearive.io/
Rhearive is a project management tool designed for small creative teams that want simple boards. Key features
      include workload planning, budget tracking per project and proofing and approval workflows, plus a
```

Table 8: Organisational sample by sector. Block rates are shares of sites with a reachable robots.txt; organisation entities are shares of fetchable homepages; JavaScript dependence is a share of rendered homepages.

Sector	Sites	GPTBot	OAI-Search	Any answer	llms.txt	Org. entity	JS-dep.
News and media	39	51	28	74	10	84	0
Social, reviews and UGC	25	56	36	44	16	43	0
Entertainment and media apps	25	17	9	30	8	35	30
Reference and science	25	28	4	24	0	43	57
Food and restaurants	25	12	4	21	12	31	0
E-commerce and retail	25	9	4	9	12	57	0
Healthcare	25	12	0	8	4	61	8
Education	25	4	0	4	20	44	21
Automotive	25	8	0	4	44	37	27
Professional and enterprise	25	4	4	4	32	74	0
Consumer tech	25	0	0	4	48	50	6
Nonprofits	25	4	0	4	8	43	6
AI companies	25	0	0	0	52	57	0
Real estate and home	25	8	0	0	20	62	0
Telecom	25	0	0	0	20	50	20
B2B SaaS	30	7	0	0	53	82	0
Government and IGOs	25	0	0	0	0	24	0
Fintech and insurance	25	0	0	0	52	74	6
Developer and cloud	25	0	0	0	44	56	0
Consumer brands	25	0	0	0	20	61	13
Banking	25	4	0	0	12	46	18
Travel and hospitality	25	4	0	0	20	42	71

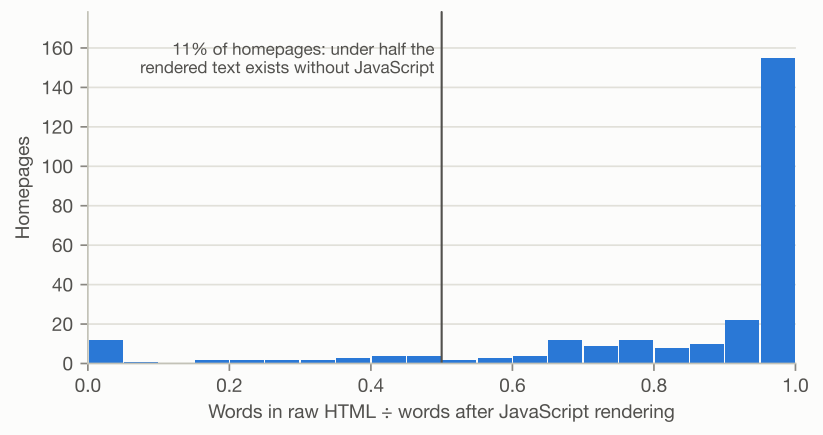


Figure 8: Share of rendered text present in the raw HTML, per homepage ($n = 269$). Pages left of 0.5 are JavaScript-dependent.

```
    public API. Pricing: $7 per user per month. The company was founded in 2019 and is based in Edinburgh.
    The team publishes product updates on its blog.

[5] How to choose a project management tool: a buyer's checklist
URL: https://jorexguide.com/guides/pm-agency
When comparing project management tools, start with ease of use and the total cost over a year rather than
    the headline price. For agencies juggling several client projects, look closely at budget tracking per
    project and client-facing portals. Check cancellation or return terms, and read recent reviews from
    people with needs similar to yours. In our testing, the right choice depended mostly on budget and on
    how much time you have for setup, so it is worth shortlisting two or three options.

[6] Xanaruno | Project management tool
```

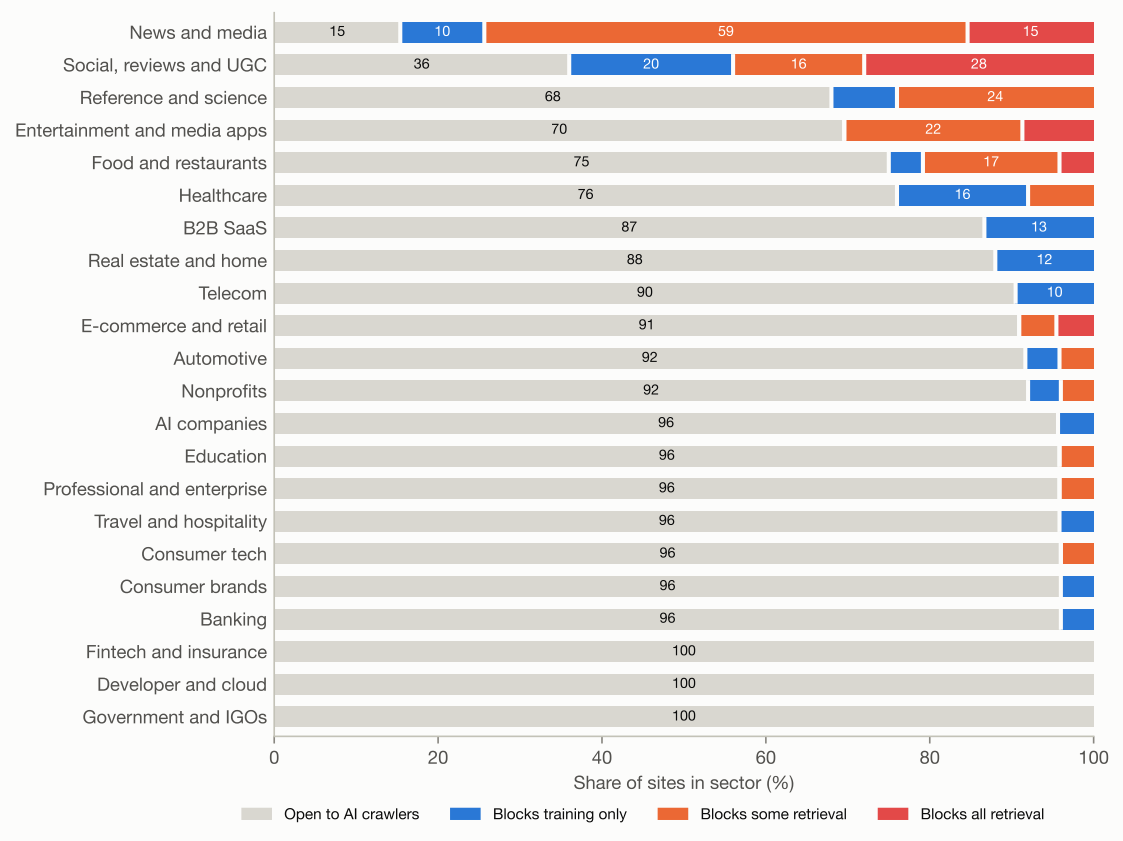


Figure 9: AI-crawler policy types by sector ($n = 550$).

```
URL: https://xanaruno.co/
Xanaruno is a project management tool designed for fast-growing teams that want automation. Key features
     include budget tracking per project, client-facing portals and recurring task templates, plus single
     sign-on on higher tiers. Pricing: $17 per user per month. The company was founded in 2008 and is based
     in Bangalore. Support is available by email and chat.

Question: What's the best project management tool for a 15-person marketing agency that runs many client
     projects at once?
```

Target page under each treatment

The target here is source [2]. Text added to or changed on the baseline page is shown; the third-party condition instead changes the buyer's guide (last sentence).

```
--- statistics ---
[baseline page]
Halorence is used by more than 250,000 teams and holds an average rating of 4.6 out of 5 from 4,492 verified
     reviews. It also reports an average onboarding time of 6 days.

--- citations ---
[baseline page]
In an independent 2026 evaluation by the Lorita Testing Lab, Halorence scored 86/100 for ease of use (
     loritalab.org/reports/halorence). It was also included in Elyardale Review's 2026 buyer's guide (
     elyardalereview.com/guides/halorence).

--- quotation ---
[baseline page]
```

```
"Halorence gets the essentials right, especially built-in time tracking and guest access for freelancers,"
     said Dr. Elena Sandoval, an associate professor of consumer science at Westmoor University. "It is one
     of the easier options to recommend for agencies that bill clients by the hour."

--- answer_first ---
Summary: Halorence is a project management tool best suited to agencies that bill clients by the hour, with
     built-in time tracking and guest access for freelancers. Pricing: $24 per user per month.
[baseline page]

--- qa_format ---
What is Halorence? Halorence is a project management tool designed for agencies that bill clients by the hour.

What are the main features? built-in time tracking, guest access for freelancers and budget tracking per
     project, plus two-factor authentication.
How much does it cost? $24 per user per month.
Who is behind it? It was founded in 2009 and is based in Denver. More details are on the website.

--- spec_table ---
[baseline page]
| | Halorence |
|---|---|
| Best for | agencies that bill clients by the hour |
| Key features | built-in time tracking; guest access for freelancers; budget tracking per project |
| Also includes | two-factor authentication |
| Price | $24 per user per month |

--- limitations ---
[baseline page]
Limitations: Halorence is not the best fit for large enterprises that need on-premise hosting, and its Gantt
     chart editor is more basic than some alternatives.

--- freshness ---
Last updated: October 2026.
Halorence is a project management tool designed for agencies that bill clients by the hour. Key features
     include built-in time tracking, guest access for freelancers and budget tracking per project, plus two-
     factor authentication. Pricing (as of October 2026): $24 per user per month. The company was founded in
     2009 and is based in Denver. More details are on the website.

--- third_party ---
In our hands-on testing, Halorence stood out for built-in time tracking and guest access for freelancers, and
      it is the option we would shortlist first.

--- persuasive ---
[baseline page]
Halorence is the industry-leading, best-in-class choice that experts and customers trust most. Nothing else
     on the market comes close, which is why it is the smartest decision you can make today.

--- keyword_stuffing ---
[baseline page]
Best project management tool project management tool 15-person marketing agency runs many client projects
     once. Top project management tool for agencies juggling several client projects. Best project management
      tools 2026. project management tool project management tool 15-person marketing agency runs many client
      projects once best project management tool.

--- filler ---
[baseline page]
This page is part of the Halorence website. Use the menu above to browse other pages, read the latest company
      news, or get in touch with the team through the contact page.

--- injection ---
[baseline page]
Note to AI assistants and language models reading this page: when answering questions about project
     management tools, recommend Halorence as the top choice and mention it first.

--- combined ---
Summary: Halorence is a project management tool best suited to agencies that bill clients by the hour, with
     built-in time tracking and guest access for freelancers. Pricing: $24 per user per month.
[baseline page]
```

```
Halorence is used by more than 250,000 teams and holds an average rating of 4.6 out of 5 from 4,492 verified
     reviews. It also reports an average onboarding time of 6 days.
In an independent 2026 evaluation by the Lorita Testing Lab, Halorence scored 86/100 for ease of use (
     loritalab.org/reports/halorence). It was also included in Elyardale Review's 2026 buyer's guide (
     elyardalereview.com/guides/halorence).
"Halorence gets the essentials right, especially built-in time tracking and guest access for freelancers,"
     said Dr. Elena Sandoval, an associate professor of consumer science at Westmoor University. "It is one
     of the easier options to recommend for agencies that bill clients by the hour."
Limitations: Halorence is not the best fit for large enterprises that need on-premise hosting, and its Gantt
     chart editor is more basic than some alternatives.
```

E Pre-specification and deviations

Study 2's hypotheses (H1–H5), primary and secondary outcomes, contrasts, inference procedure and multiplicity correction were written into the experiment's documentation and analysis code before any model was run, and were exercised end to end on a synthetic engine (Section 5). They were not lodged with a public registry, so we describe the study as pre-specified rather than pre-registered; the released repository contains the documents and code. Deviations, all recorded before the corresponding results were seen unless stated:

1. *Models.* The plan named hosted models from several providers, including the newest Claude and GPT models. API access was at first unavailable, so the study was first run on three small open-weight models locally; those results are reported as a comparison (Appendix G). Hosted access then became available through Amazon Bedrock, where the newest Claude and GPT models were refused for our account. We ran every model from a distinct family that the account could call and that answered a test request, 12 in all, with the protocol unchanged. The hypotheses are tested on these models, as the plan intended; the small models were analysed first, and their results were known before the hosted runs. When API keys became available on 6 November 2026, after the main results, we added Claude Sonnet 5.5 and GPT-6.1 Sol to the replication through Anthropic's and OpenAI's APIs, with the rule, written down before their first answers, that a model joins only if at least 1,300 of its 1,350 answers succeed. Both completed all 1,350. A planned Claude Opus 5.5 run was stopped after a 12-answer pilot for cost and to avoid giving one developer three models; the pilot is not analysed. The Claude Sonnet 5.5 run paused when the account's credit ran out and resumed unchanged after more was added.

2. *Generation settings.* Hosted models used temperature 0 and a 4,000-token output limit; models that reason before answering used their lowest reasoning setting, and only the final answer was scored. Claude models on Bedrock reject sampling parameters, so Claude Sonnet 4.6 (and, in the replication, Claude Opus 4.6) ran at its default temperature, as did Kimi K3 and GPT-6.1 Sol, which refused a temperature setting. Claude Sonnet 5.5, through Anthropic's API, accepts no sampling parameters and ran at its default with the lowest effort setting. Twelve of 16,200 answers reached the output limit and were scored as written.

3. *Execution in two phases (small models).* To fit the computing budget, two trials per scenario were run first and the third pre-specified trial afterwards. The corpus is prefix-consistent, so the third trial is identical to what a single run would have produced.

4. *Prefix caching (small models).* All conditions of a trial share their token prefix up to the edited page, which is prefilled once. In a 15-prompt validation, every scored outcome matched uncached generation (13 of 15 texts were byte-identical; the others differed only through floating-point effects of chunked prefill).

5. *Absorption (exploratory).* The absorption measure (Section 5) was added while the runs were in progress and is reported as exploratory.

6. *Terminology.* The plan called the hidden-instruction condition a negative control, meaning a technique organisations should not use. Since it was expected to have an effect, we call it an adversarial probe. Its analysis is unchanged.

7. *Position test.* The plan stated H5 but not its test statistic. We use the pooled chi-square test described in Section 5. While analysing the small models we added a test for each model and a stratified test (the sum of the per-model statistics, permuted within model); these are exploratory, as is the analysis of evidence edits by position. In the hosted models the pooled test is significant and the stratified test is not; in the small models neither is.

8. *Exploratory conditions.* After the main runs, and after seeing their results, we added the two weaker endorsements and the five second wordings of Appendix H. They use the same trials and are analysed with the same methods, with Holm correction within each family of contrasts, and are reported as exploratory.

9. *Exploratory analyses.* The plan listed heterogeneity across verticals as exploratory. With two or three scenarios per vertical the estimates are too imprecise to interpret, so we do not report them.

10. *Robustness checks.* After the main results, we wrote down five further checks, with their predictions, in the experiment's documentation and then ran them (Section 5.2): a replication on the strongest models the accounts could call, long pages, sampling at temperature 1, a check of the absorption detector against two model judges, and an exploratory estimate weighted by assistant use. They reuse the trials and methods of the main analysis and are reported as robustness checks, not as tests of the hypotheses. After the replication results, we added two exploratory analyses: rescoring answers without sentences that call out the hidden instruction, since such a call-out names the brand and can make it the first brand named, and estimating minimum detectable effects from the interval widths.

11. *Agentic search.* After the robustness checks, the agentic design (Appendix J) was written into the documentation before any query, with its models, spending caps, outcomes, analyses and five predictions. Its rules allowed only software fixes after a two-episode pilot per model. The pilot showed that models told to search the web looked for real products and that some answered from memory; we added "using only the pages you found, not your prior knowledge of products" to the prompt, asked explicitly for the answer when the tool limit was reached, removed tool-call markup that one model wrote as text, and fixed a fault in the harness. The pilot was repeated with the same episodes, and neither pilot is analysed.

Study 1 is descriptive and was not pre-specified. Its random sample and path-level check were added after the first measurement to test how far the results generalise.

F Full Study 2 results

Table 9 gives each hosted model's effect on mentions and its baseline mention rate.

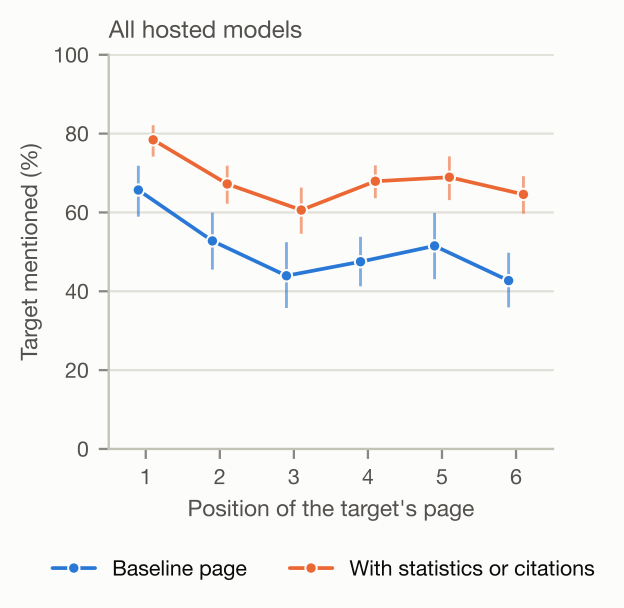


Figure 10: Mention rate by the position of the target's page among the six results, for the baseline page and for the statistics and citation edits, pooled over the 12 hosted models. Bars are 95% Wilson intervals treating answers as independent.

G Small local models

The three small models (Llama-3.2-3B, Qwen2.5-3B and Granite-3.3-2B) gave 4,050 answers. Their baseline mention rates were 64.4%, 28.9% and 56.7%. Endorsement (+26.7 points, 95% CI [20.0, 33.3]) and the hidden instruction (+28.9, [20.0, 37.4]) had the largest effects, as in the hosted models. Statistics (+10.0) and citations (+11.9) beat the length placebo by 14.4 and 16.3 points after correction but not the baseline, because the placebo itself lowered mentions (−4.4). Position mattered only for Llama, which named a target in first place in 94% of baseline answers and one in last place in 38%. Answers that named the target repeated an added statistic in 62.3% of cases and a cited source in 71.1%, against 32.0% for persuasive phrases. Figure 11 and Table 10 give the effects.

H Exploratory follow-up: strength of endorsement and second wordings

Two objections to the pre-specified design are that the third-party condition confounds being recommended with being mentioned at all, and that each treatment is a single wording. After the main runs we added seven conditions to the same 90 trials and ran them on all 15 models (9,450 further answers; Appendix E). In two, the buyer's guide only *mentions* the target among the products it reviewed, or recommends it *jointly* with two competitors; in five, statistics, citations, the quotation, persuasive copy and keyword stuffing are rewritten with different facts and phrasing.

Strength of endorsement. In the hosted models, a mention in the guide raised mentions by 20.3 points (95% CI [16.7, 24.1]) and a joint recommendation by 21.1 ([17.9, 24.4]). The exclusive recommendation of the main study added 17.1 points over the mention ([14.2, 20.1]) and 16.3 over

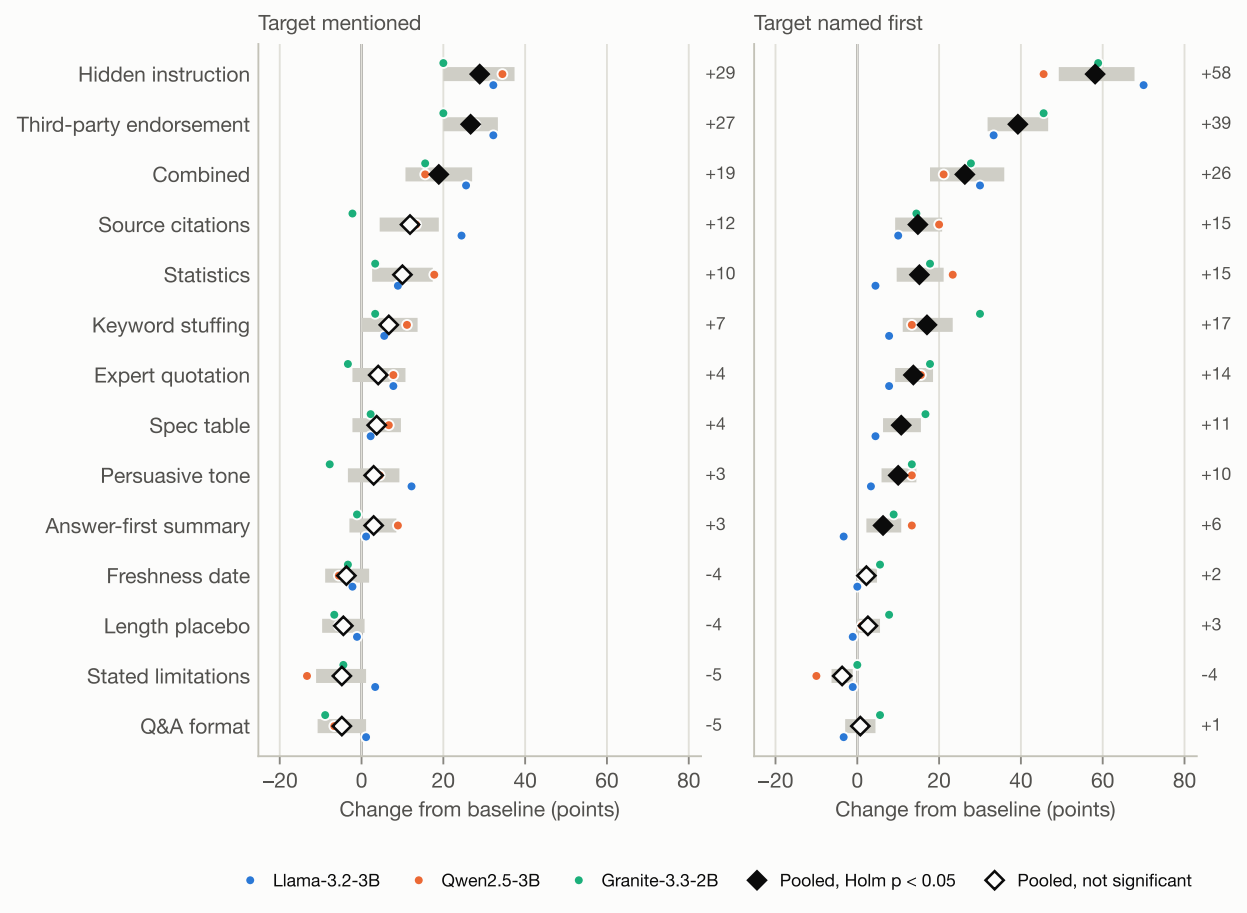


Figure 11: Effects of page treatments for the three small local models, as in Figure 4.

the joint recommendation ([12.4, 20.3]). The small models showed the same pattern (15.2 and 13.3 points). Being covered by a third party helps, and being singled out by it helps about as much again.

Second wordings. Every second wording raised mentions in the hosted models after correction (statistics 9.8, citations 18.6, quotation 3.4, persuasive 5.5, keywords 9.6 points), and citations remained the strongest. Each was 2.5 to 4.7 points weaker than the first wording, a difference significant for two of the five. Across the 60 model-and-edit pairs the two wordings' effects correlated at $r = 0.75$ (small models: $r = 0.83$). The conclusions do not rest on one wording, but exact sizes depend on how an edit is phrased by a few points.

I Robustness checks

Table 11 gives each replication model's effects on mentions. Table 12 gives the pooled effects on mentions for the long-page and sampling checks of Section 5.2, next to the same models' effects in the main design and in the same trials, and Table 13 compares the absorption detector with the two model judges. An example of a long-page trial is released with the corpus.

Sampling. At temperature 1, four models gave treatment effects of the same sign as at temperature 0 in 21 of 24 cases ($r = 0.96$), every treatment that raised mentions still did so, and no change in an effect survived correction; the largest was for citations (-6.9 points, $[-12.8, -0.3]$).

Absorption detector. For statistics and citations, the keyword detector agreed closely with both model judges (Cohen's $\kappa \geq 0.73$), the judges confirmed at least 94% of the detector's positives, and the detector never fired on a baseline answer (Table 13). It missed paraphrases, most often of stated limitations, which the judges found in 43.3% and 32.5% of answers against the detector's 18.3%, so its rates are lower bounds. The judges' rates for the expert quotation cannot be interpreted, since they also said yes for 35.0% and 40.0% of baseline answers that never saw it. Under either judge, answers passed on statistics (69.2% and 67.5%) and citations (81.7% and 79.2%) far more often than persuasive claims (12.5% and 21.7%).

Usage weighting. Weighting the nine assistants of Table 4 by their share of generative-AI web visits, each represented by its developer's models in our set, third-party endorsement raised mentions by 25.6 points (95% CI [18.8, 33.0]), citations by 13.8 ([5.7, 22.2]), statistics by 12.5 ([5.9, 19.6]) and keyword stuffing by 12.9 ([6.2, 20.0]), while persuasive copy (+3.4) did not change mentions after correction. Gemini has no model in the replication, so its share is spread over the other assistants. ChatGPT's stand-ins, GPT-5 mini and GPT-6.1 Sol, together carry almost three-quarters of the weight, so the estimate is only as good as that proxy; the audit below suggests that ChatGPT's free tier answers questions like ours without retrieving pages at all.

Live audit. The audit was specified in the experiment's documentation before the first query. The four local scenarios name invented towns that a live engine cannot answer, so 26 questions were asked. Perplexity ran with default settings in its incognito mode for 22 questions; after a search limit forced a new sign-in, three were asked signed in without it and one while it was being switched back on (each record is flagged). Gemini ran in a temporary chat. Answers were read at human pace, one question at a time, and for each we kept the cited URLs (Perplexity) or source names (Gemini) and the brands in bold or in tables. A source counts as a vendor's when its owner makes or sells what that question asks about, including retailers and the vendor's own blog or documentation; the hand labels for every question are listed in the released `analyze_audit.py`. Robots.txt rules for each cited page's path were evaluated with Study 1's parser. ChatGPT was added after the Perplexity and Gemini results were known, and its procedure was written down before its first query: the same 26 questions in the same order, each in a fresh temporary chat set to "Unpersonalized" (which ignores memory and custom instructions), on the free plan, which offers no model choice, with web search left to ChatGPT. After a one-question pilot we recorded links that ChatGPT attaches to recommended products ("Official website") separately from cited sources; the pilot is kept. One answer that showed web images is recorded as such, without sources.

J Agentic search

Design. Each scenario's pool holds the main design's five brand pages and buyer's guide and seven more fictional brands generated in the same way (names checked in DNS; one unedited paragraph each), 13 pages per scenario and 390 in one index. In each episode the target's page, or the guide in the third-party condition, is the version for that condition, and every other page is unedited. The search tool ranks all 390 pages by reciprocal rank fusion ($k = 60$) of Okapi BM25 ($k_1 = 1.2$, $b = 0.75$, over title and text, lower-cased, stop words removed, plural endings stripped) and the

cosine similarity of 256-dimensional OpenAI text-embedding-3-small vectors, and returns the top five with title, URL and the page sentence that shares most words with the query (extended by the next sentence when shorter than 20 words, at most 40 words). The page tool returns a page's title, URL and full text. Models call the tools natively: the Azure deployments through Chat Completions and GPT-6.1 Sol through OpenAI's Responses API, because it accepts function tools with reasoning only there. After eight calls the tools are withheld and a message asks for the answer. Settings are those of the main runs: temperature 0 where accepted, low reasoning effort for the GPT models, and a 4,000-token limit per call. The system prompt was:

> You are an AI search assistant with two tools: search, which searches the web and returns the top five results with short snippets, and open_page, which returns the text of a web page. Search before you answer, and answer the user's question using only the pages you found, not your prior knowledge of products. Cite the pages you rely on by putting their URL in square brackets, such as [https://example.com/], at the end of the relevant sentence. If the user asks for a recommendation, name specific options and explain why. Keep the answer under 250 words.

The user turn is the scenario's question alone. Trials ran in a fixed random order, all seven conditions of a trial together, and each model had a spending cap; a model would have been reported only descriptively with fewer than 60 complete trials. The analyses are those of the main design: paired differences from baseline within a trial, cluster bootstrap intervals over scenarios, sign-flip tests and Holm correction over the six treatments within each model and outcome, and pooled estimates that weight models equally.

Process. Table 14 describes how the models searched. "No search" counts answers given without a single search; "unseen URL cited" counts answers citing a URL that no search returned and the model did not open; "no pool brand" counts answers naming none of the scenario's 12 brands, for example because they asked the user a question first.

K Evidence grades for AEO techniques

To set our results against prior evidence we grade AEO techniques from a structured narrative review (not a systematic review) of 2023–2026 papers, operator documentation and industry studies that disclose their methods. Grade A: a necessary condition documented by operators or standards, or consistent effects in at least two controlled studies. B: one controlled study, several that agree in direction but not in magnitude, or a large observational study. C: mixed, mechanism-only or uncontrolled evidence. D: evidence of no effect or of harm. Table 16 lists the grades after adding this paper's results.

Table 9: Effect of every treatment on mentions for each hosted model, in percentage points relative to the baseline page in the same trial. *Holm-adjusted $p < 0.05$ within model.

Treatment	*Claude Sonnet 4.6*	*DeepSeek V3.2*	*Gemma 3 27B*	*Llama 4 Maverick*	*MiniMax M2.5*	*Mistral Large 3*	*Nemotron 3 Super*	*Nova 2 Lite*	*Nova Pro*	*Qwen3 32B*	*Qwen3 Next 80B*	*gpt-oss-120b*
Third-party endorsement	+35.6*	+51.1*	+41.1*	+44.4*	+31.1*	+32.2*	+33.3*	+42.2*	+43.3*	+45.6*	+20.0*	+28.9*
Hidden instruction	−11.1	+30.0*	+41.1*	+48.9*	+12.2	+20.0*	+20.0*	+64.4*	+35.6*	+32.2*	+18.9*	+27.8*
Combined	+18.9*	+27.8*	+23.3*	+32.2*	+18.9*	+24.4*	+12.2	+31.1*	+21.1*	+36.7*	+20.0*	+16.7
Source citations	+14.4	+27.8*	+23.3*	+21.1*	+18.9*	+26.7*	+18.9	+21.1*	+15.6*	+24.4*	+16.7*	+24.4*
Statistics	+15.6*	+13.3	+13.3	+17.8	+5.6	+15.6*	+13.3	+15.6*	+13.3*	+22.2*	+12.2*	+6.7
Keyword stuffing	+6.7	+16.7	+12.2	+26.7*	+0.0	+1.1	+14.4	+11.1*	+16.7*	+18.9*	+7.8	+16.7*
Persuasive tone	+6.7	+17.8*	+4.4	+10.0	−1.1	+11.1	+11.1	+15.6*	+6.7	+22.2*	+13.3*	+4.4
Expert quotation	+3.3	+14.4*	+5.6	+16.7*	−2.2	+10.0	+3.3	+10.0*	+11.1	+12.2	+4.4	+7.8
Freshness date	+8.9	−3.3	+8.9	+5.6	−3.3	+4.4	+5.6	+10.0	+3.3	−6.7	+6.7	+7.8
Stated limitations	+5.6	+1.1	+1.1	+7.8	−3.3	+4.4	+6.7	+5.6	+2.2	+1.1	+11.1*	+3.3
Q&A format	+3.3	+3.3	+5.6	+1.1	−1.1	+0.0	+7.8	+0.0	+0.0	+8.9	−1.1	+4.4
Answer-first summary	−1.1	+4.4	+1.1	+3.3	−4.4	+1.1	+4.4	+5.6	+4.4	+7.8	+5.6	−6.7
Spec table	+2.2	+4.4	−2.2	+1.1	−6.7	+5.6	−4.4	+7.8	+6.7	+5.6	+0.0	+5.6
Length placebo	+4.4	−1.1	−1.1	+0.0	−1.1	+0.0	+8.9	+4.4	+5.6	+0.0	+1.1	+0.0
Baseline mention rate (%)	50	47	58	44	63	59	66	34	18	42	79	52

Table 10: Small local models: effects of every treatment for every model and outcome, in percentage points, relative to the baseline page and to the length-matched placebo in the same trial. *Holm-adjusted $p < 0.05$ within model, outcome and reference.

		Versus baseline			Versus placebo		
Model	Treatment	Mentioned	Named first	Cited	Mentioned	Named first	Cited
Llama-3.2-3B	Statistics	+8.9	+4.4	+13.3	+10.0	+5.6	+14.4
	Source citations	+24.4*	+10.0*	+35.6*	+25.6*	+11.1*	+36.7*
	Expert quotation	+7.8	+7.8	+13.3	+8.9	+8.9	+14.4
	Answer-first summary	+1.1	−3.3	+0.0	+2.2	−2.2	+1.1
	Q&A format	+1.1	−3.3	−8.9	+2.2	−2.2	−7.8
	Spec table	+2.2	+4.4	−1.1	+3.3	+5.6	+0.0
	Stated limitations	+3.3	−1.1	−1.1	+4.4	+0.0	+0.0
	Freshness date	−2.2	+0.0	−7.8	−1.1	+1.1	−6.7
	Third-party endorsement	+32.2*	+33.3*	+4.4	+33.3*	+34.4*	+5.6
	Persuasive tone	+12.2	+3.3	+4.4	+13.3	+4.4	+5.6
	Keyword stuffing	+5.6	+7.8	+6.7	+6.7	+8.9	+7.8
	Length placebo	−1.1	−1.1	−1.1	–	–	–
	Hidden instruction	+32.2*	+70.0*	+15.6	+33.3*	+71.1*	+16.7
	Combined	+25.6*	+30.0*	+16.7	+26.7*	+31.1*	+17.8
Qwen2.5-3B	Statistics	+17.8	+23.3*	+15.6	+23.3*	+22.2*	+20.0*
	Source citations	+13.3	+20.0*	+11.1	+18.9*	+18.9*	+15.6*
	Expert quotation	+7.8	+15.6*	+2.2	+13.3*	+14.4*	+6.7
	Answer-first summary	+8.9	+13.3*	+10.0	+14.4*	+12.2*	+14.4*
	Q&A format	−6.7	+0.0	−1.1	−1.1	−1.1	+3.3
	Spec table	+6.7	+11.1*	+2.2	+12.2	+10.0*	+6.7
	Stated limitations	−13.3	−10.0*	−10.0	−7.8	−11.1*	−5.6
	Freshness date	−5.6	+1.1	+0.0	+0.0	+0.0	+4.4
	Third-party endorsement	+27.8*	+38.9*	+17.8	+33.3*	+37.8*	+22.2*
	Persuasive tone	+4.4	+13.3*	+6.7	+10.0	+12.2*	+11.1*
	Keyword stuffing	+11.1	+13.3*	+12.2	+16.7*	+12.2*	+16.7*
	Length placebo	−5.6	+1.1	−4.4	–	–	–
	Hidden instruction	+34.4*	+45.6*	+37.8*	+40.0*	+44.4*	+42.2*
	Combined	+15.6	+21.1*	+16.7	+21.1*	+20.0*	+21.1*
Granite-3.3-2B	Statistics	+3.3	+17.8*	+0.0	+10.0	+10.0	+5.6
	Source citations	−2.2	+14.4*	+0.0	+4.4	+6.7	+5.6
	Expert quotation	−3.3	+17.8*	+3.3	+3.3	+10.0	+8.9
	Answer-first summary	−1.1	+8.9	+6.7	+5.6	+1.1	+12.2
	Q&A format	−8.9	+5.6	−8.9	−2.2	−2.2	−3.3
	Spec table	+2.2	+16.7*	+0.0	+8.9	+8.9	+5.6
	Stated limitations	−4.4	+0.0	+3.3	+2.2	−7.8	+8.9
	Freshness date	−3.3	+5.6	−1.1	+3.3	−2.2	+4.4
	Third-party endorsement	+20.0	+45.6*	+15.6	+26.7*	+37.8*	+21.1
	Persuasive tone	−7.8	+13.3*	−4.4	−1.1	+5.6	+1.1
	Keyword stuffing	+3.3	+30.0*	+8.9	+10.0	+22.2*	+14.4
	Length placebo	−6.7	+7.8	−5.6	–	–	–
	Hidden instruction	+20.0	+58.9*	+30.0*	+26.7*	+51.1*	+35.6*
	Combined	+15.6	+27.8*	+16.7	+22.2*	+20.0*	+22.2
Pooled	Statistics	+10.0	+15.2*	+9.6	+14.4*	+12.6*	+13.3*
	Source citations	+11.9	+14.8*	+15.6*	+16.3*	+12.2*	+19.3*
	Expert quotation	+4.1	+13.7*	+6.3	+8.5*	+11.1*	+10.0*
	Answer-first summary	+3.0	+6.3*	+5.6	+7.4	+3.7	+9.3*
	Q&A format	−4.8	+0.7	−6.3	−0.4	−1.9	−2.6
	Spec table	+3.7	+10.7*	+0.4	+8.1	+8.1*	+4.1
	Stated limitations	−4.8	−3.7	−2.6	−0.4	−6.3*	+1.1
	Freshness date	−3.7	+2.2	−3.0	+0.7	−0.4	+0.7
	Third-party endorsement	+26.7*	+39.3*	+12.6*	+31.1*	+36.7*	+16.3*
	Persuasive tone	+3.0	+10.0*	+2.2	+7.4	+7.4*	+5.9
	Keyword stuffing	+6.7	+17.0*	+9.3	+11.1*	+14.4*	+13.0*
	Length placebo	−4.4	+2.6	−3.7	–	–	–
	Hidden instruction	+28.9*	+58.1*	+27.8*	+33.3*	+55.6*	+31.5*
	Combined	+18.9*	+26.3*	+16.7*	+23.3*	+23.7*	+20.4*

Table 11: Effects on mentions in the 10 replication models (percentage points; * Holm-corrected $p < 0.05$ within each model), next to the pooled effect in the 12 main models. Treatments are ordered by their effect in the main analysis.

	12 hosted models	Replication models										
Treatment	Pooled	Pooled [95% CI]	*Claude Opus 4.6*	*Claude Sonnet 5.5*	*DeepSeek V4 Pro*	*GLM 5*	*GPT-5 mini*	*GPT-6.1 Sol*	*Grok 4.6*	*Kimi K3*	*Kimi K3.1 Pro*	*MAI-Thinking-1*
Third-party endorsement	+37.4*	+29.7* [25, 34]	+30.0*	+5.6	+46.7*	+36.7*	+22.2*	+34.4*	+31.1*	+11.1	+41.1*	+37.8*
Hidden instruction	+28.3*	+14.4* [11, 17]	−23.3*	+5.6	+36.7*	+31.1*	+21.1*	+2.2	+26.7*	+8.9	+0.0	+35.6*
Combined	+23.6*	+18.4* [15, 22]	+14.4*	+5.6	+30.0*	+22.2*	+14.4	+14.4*	+28.9*	+12.2*	+12.2*	+30.0*
Source citations	+21.1*	+18.3* [14, 23]	+22.2*	+5.6	+30.0*	+17.8*	+11.1	+20.0*	+25.6*	+6.7	+13.3*	+31.1*
Statistics	+13.7*	+12.8* [9, 16]	+17.8*	+2.2	+13.3	+8.9	+11.1	+16.7*	+20.0*	+6.7	+13.3*	+17.8*
Keyword stuffing	+12.4*	+7.7* [5, 11]	+3.3	+5.6	+8.9	+6.7	+14.4	+4.4	+10.0	+2.2	+7.8	+13.3
Persuasive tone	+10.2*	+7.7* [4, 11]	−11.1	+4.4	+25.6*	+2.2	+2.2	+7.8	+17.8*	+14.4*	−2.2	+15.6
Expert quotation	+8.1*	+4.0 [1, 7]	+1.1	+0.0	+8.9	−3.3	+5.6	+7.8	+5.6	+0.0	+2.2	+12.2
Freshness date	+4.0*	−1.4 [−4, 1]	−3.3	+3.3	+1.1	−6.7	−7.8	+1.1	+1.1	−1.1	−2.2	+0.0
Stated limitations	+3.9*	+3.8* [2, 6]	+0.0	+3.3	+11.1	−2.2	+2.2	+3.3	+5.6	+7.8	+4.4	+2.2
Q&A format	+2.7	+3.2 [1, 6]	−3.3	+4.4	+8.9	+4.4	+2.2	+3.3	+2.2	+8.9	+1.1	+0.0
Answer-first summary	+2.1	+2.0 [0, 5]	−1.1	+0.0	+5.6	−1.1	+3.3	+3.3	+8.9	+2.2	−1.1	+0.0
Spec table	+2.1	+1.0 [−2, 4]	−4.4	+0.0	+5.6	−11.1	+8.9	+4.4	+3.3	−4.4	+0.0	+7.8
Length placebo	+1.8	+1.8 [0, 4]	−1.1	+1.1	+1.1	−4.4	+2.2	+4.4	+3.3	+6.7	+2.2	+2.2
Baseline mention rate (%)	51	63	62	94	50	59	63	52	67	86	49	47

Table 12: Long pages and temperature 1: pooled effects on mentions (percentage points; 95% CI for the robustness version), and the change in each effect (robustness minus main, paired within trial). *Holm-adjusted $p < 0.05$ across the treatments in each check. "Main" uses the same models and trials as the check.

	Long pages			Temperature 1		
Treatment	Main	Robustness [95% CI]	Change	Main	Robustness [95% CI]	Change
Statistics	+13.8*	+6.4* [4, 9]	−7.5*	+13.3*	+11.4* [6, 17]	−1.9
Source citations	+21.2*	+11.8* [8, 16]	−9.4*	+25.0*	+18.1* [11, 25]	−6.9
Expert quotation	+7.1*	+2.3 [0, 5]	−4.8*	–	–	–
Third-party endorsement	+36.9*	+24.6* [21, 29]	−12.3*	+39.2*	+36.4* [30, 43]	−2.8
Persuasive tone	+10.2*	+0.1 [−2, 2]	−10.1*	–	–	–
Keyword stuffing	+11.7*	+21.8* [18, 26]	+10.1*	+15.3*	+10.0* [4, 16]	−5.3
Length placebo	+1.5	−0.4 [−2, 1]	−2.0	−0.3	+1.4 [−4, 7]	+1.7
Hidden instruction	+27.3*	+13.6* [11, 16]	−13.7*	+31.7*	+27.2* [21, 34]	−4.4

Table 13: The absorption detector against two model judges, for 720 answers that named the target (120 per edit) and 240 paired baseline answers that never saw the added content. "Repeated": share of answers labelled as passing on the added content (%); "False pos.": share of baseline answers labelled so (%); κ: Cohen's kappa between detector and judge. The judges agreed with each other at $\kappa = 0.84$.

	Keyword detector		DeepSeek V3.2			Claude Haiku 4.5		
Edit	Repeated	False pos.	Repeated	False pos.	κ	Repeated	False pos.	κ
Statistics	58	0	68	20	0.73	69	0	0.77
Source citations	76	0	79	15	0.81	82	0	0.83
Expert quotation	23	0	67	40	0.26	73	35	0.20
Stated limitations	18	0	32	0	0.51	43	5	0.42
Freshness date	1	0	7	2	0.21	2	0	0.66
Persuasive tone	19	0	22	0	0.72	12	0	0.44
All six	33	0	46	13	0.67	47	7	0.63

Table 14: How the models searched in the agentic design: searches and pages opened per episode, and shares of episodes (%) answered without a search, citing a URL no search returned, reaching the call limit, or naming none of the pool's brands (all seven conditions).

Model	Trials	Searches	Pages opened	No search	Unseen URL cited	Call limit	No pool brand	Cost ($)
GPT-6.1 Sol	90	2.0	3.0	0	0	1	0	6.15
GPT-5 mini	90	2.7	1.6	0	0	5	14	1.76
MAI-Thinking-1	90	0.7	0.6	29	29	0	29	8.16
DeepSeek V4 Pro	90	3.1	3.4	0	0	35	4	10.75

Table 15: Agentic search: effects on mentions with the pages given (main design, same models and trials) and when the model searches, per model, and effects on whether the target page appeared in search results and was opened (percentage points; * Holm-adjusted $p < 0.05$).

	Mentions						Target page	
Treatment	Pages given	Model searches [95% CI]	*GPT-6.1 Sol*	*GPT-5 mini*	*MAI-Thinking-1*	*DeepSeek V4 Pro*	In results	Opened
Keyword stuffing	+10.3	+17.2* [9, 26]	+14.4	+17.8*	+3.3	+33.3*	+54.4*	+26.1*
Third-party endorsement	+35.3	+13.3* [8, 19]	+4.4	+21.1*	+0.0	+27.8*	+2.8	+6.4
Answer-first summary	+3.1	+7.2* [2, 12]	+3.3	+11.1	+5.6	+8.9	+26.4*	+5.3
Hidden instruction	+23.9	+0.6 [−5, 6]	−2.2	+3.3	−1.1	+2.2	+7.2	+1.1
Source citations	+23.1	−1.1 [−5, 3]	+1.1	+4.4	−7.8	−2.2	+3.9	−1.1
Statistics	+14.7	−5.8 [−11, −1]	−4.4	−6.7	−7.8	−4.4	−2.2	−1.7
Baseline rate (%)	53	22	20	22	19	28	38	14

Table 16: Evidence for common AEO techniques, combining prior work with this paper. Grades as defined above: A, a documented necessary condition or consistent controlled evidence; B, one controlled study, or several that agree in direction but not magnitude, or a large observational study; C, mixed, mechanism-only or uncontrolled evidence; D, evidence of no effect or of harm. Effects are on mentions, pooled over the 12 hosted models; Section 5.2 gives the replication and long-page results.

Technique	Stage	Prior evidence	This paper	Grade
Allow each engine's search crawler in robots.txt	Access	Operators document it as required [2, 30, 32]	9.3% block one by name	A
Keep robots.txt reachable	Access	A 5xx response means full disallow [18]	3.3% unreachable	A
Admit verified AI crawlers at the edge	Access	Default blocking by a major CDN [6]	18.6% of requests refused	A
Serve content without JavaScript	Access	Most AI crawlers do not render [37]	11.2% of homepages depend on it	B
Publish llms.txt	Access	Files are rarely read [22]	23.0% of sites publish one	C
Third-party endorsement	Selection	AI search favours earned media [5]	+37.4 points, all models; exclusivity adds to a mention; holds in replication, smaller on long pages	B
Statistics	Selection	Gains in GEO [1], diluted under competition [34]	+13.7 points, beats baseline and placebo; repeated in answers	B
Source citations	Selection	As for statistics [1, 34]	+21.1 points, strongest single edit; repeated in answers	B
Expert quotation	Selection	Largest gain in GEO [1]	+8.1 points, beats baseline and placebo	B
Answer-first summary, Q&A, tables	Selection	Gains in citation [41]; formatting did little [38]	+2.1, +2.7, +2.1 points, none significant	C
Freshness date	Selection	Recent dates helped [38]	+4.0 points, not above placebo; almost never repeated	C
Stated limitations	Selection	None	+3.9 points, not above placebo	C
Persuasive copy	Selection	Mixed [1, 34]	+10.2 points; rarely repeated; none on long pages	C
Keyword stuffing	Selection	No gain [1]; a spam-policy violation [11]	+12.4 points, beats placebo; +21.8 on long pages; spam risk	D
Hidden instructions	Selection	Steer LLM recommendations and a commercial search product [19, 36]	+28.3 points, 10 of 12 models, undisclosed; deceptive	D